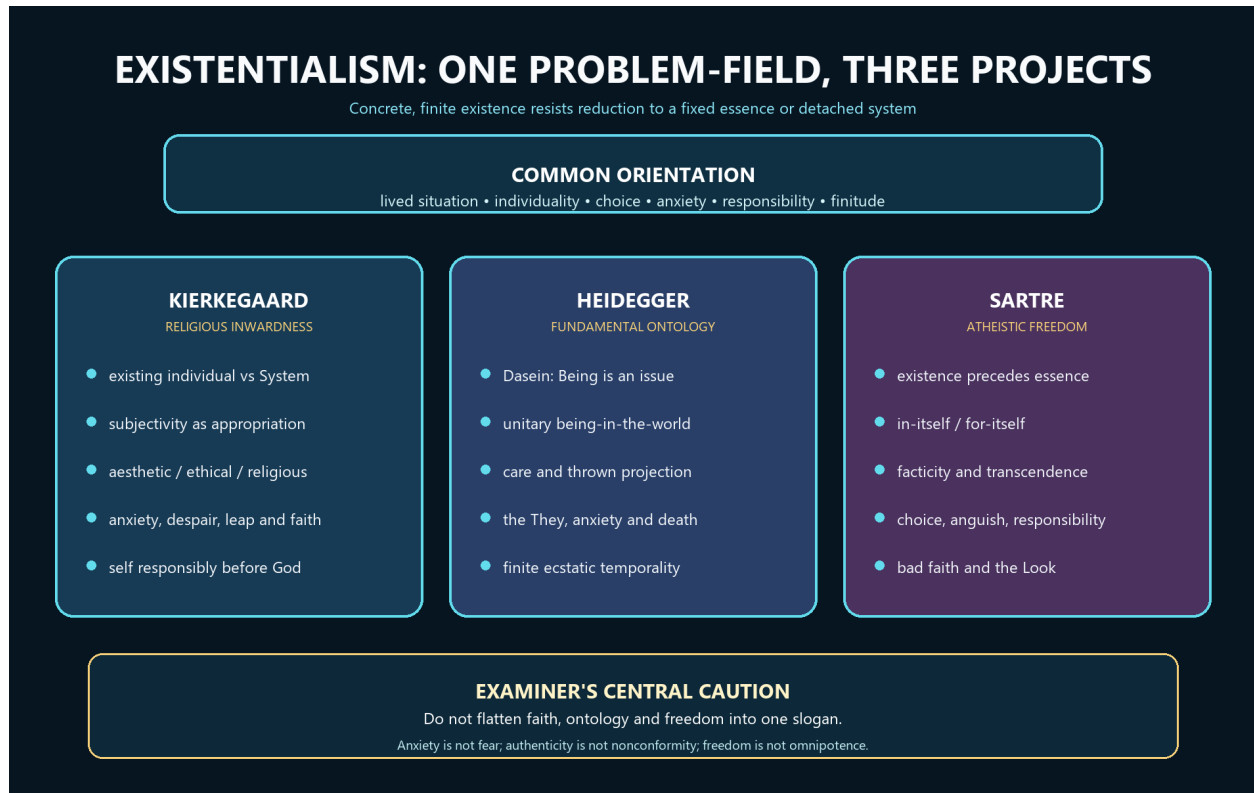


Existentialism - Learner-v2

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Existentialism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

RAPID REVISION 1 - Foundational Map - Three Thinkers, One Shared Conviction, Radical Differences

Rapid recall

- Family likeness = **existence is prior to essence in the human case**; concrete, deciding existence before any fixed nature. - **Three-way split**: Kierkegaard (theistic, anti-Hegelian, *den Enkelte*, faith) | Sartre (atheistic, *pour-soi*, radical freedom) | Heidegger (ontological, *Dasein*, finitude).
- Only **Sartre** says "existence precedes essence"; Heidegger **rejects** it; Kierkegaard never uses it.
- Enemies: Hegel's System / determinism and bad faith / Cartesian dualism and *das Man*.
- **Syllabus anomaly**: printed "Sarte" is retained only when quoting the syllabus; spell "Sartre" otherwise. - **Trap**: "the existentialists share the slogan existence precedes essence." Wrong - it is Sartre's alone. - Ownership: **14** owned parts 2018-2025, at least one every year. - **Practice link**: MCQs 1-4; frames every PYQ.

RAPID REVISION 2 - Kierkegaard - The Single Individual, Truth Is Subjectivity, the Three Stages, the Leap and Indirect Communication

Rapid recall

- **Target**: Hegel's System and "the crowd"; the individual (*den Enkelte*) cannot be sublated into Absolute Spirit.
- **Truth is subjectivity** (*Climacus*, *Postscript* 1846) = the passionate *how* of appropriation, not relativism; complement "**subjectivity is untruth**" (sin/finitude). - **Three stages**: aesthetic (boredom/despair) -> ethical (guilt) -> religious (faith, the paradox); qualitative spheres crossed by **the leap** (*Springet*), never by maturation.
- **Fear and Trembling** (Johannes de Silentio, 1843): Abraham, **teleological suspension of the ethical**, knight of faith, infinite resignation, double movement. - **Indirect communication / pseudonymity**: existential truth cannot be handed over as a result; cite the pseudonym; *Climacus revokes the Postscript* (self-consuming text).
- **Key line**: "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible." - **Traps**: subjectivity = relativism (wrong); stages are chronological (wrong - they are qualitative, relapse is possible); "leap of faith" is Kierkegaard's phrase (it is the English tradition's). - **Practice link**: MCQs 5-8; PYQ 2020 Q3(a), 2022 Q4(a), 2023 Q1(d), 2024 Q1(e).

RAPID REVISION 3 - Existence and Essence - Sartre's Slogan, the Paper-Knife, and Heidegger's Rejection of Humanism

Rapid recall

- **Existence precedes essence** = Sartre's slogan: no God, no artisan, no prior human nature; the *pour-soi* is a **project** that makes itself. Paper-knife (*coupe-papier*) analogy reversed for man.
- **Atheism is a premise** of Sartre's version (if God existed, essence would precede existence) - so the slogan is *not* definitional of all existentialism.
- **Heidegger rejects it** (*Letter on Humanism*, 1947): "the essence of *Dasein* lies in its existence" is ontological, not voluntarist; Sartre stays in the metaphysics of subjectivity; man = "shepherd of Being."
- **Provenance**: slogan is from *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1945 lecture, pub. 1946), not *Being and Nothingness*.
- **Freedom link**: no essence -> radical freedom -> "condemned to be free" -> responsibility (choosing an image of man). - **Trap**: attributing the slogan to Heidegger or to "all existentialists." - **Practice link**: MCQs 9-12; PYQ 2024 Q4(a).

RAPID REVISION 4 - Sartre I - Radical Freedom, Choice, Responsibility, and the Moods of Anguish, Abandonment and Despair

Rapid recall

- **Freedom = what the pour-soi IS**, not a property it has; consciousness is nihilating, self-surpassing. - **"Man is condemned to be free"** (*Existentialism Is a Humanism*, 1946): thrown, then inescapably free; **non-choice is a choice**; total responsibility, **no excuses**. - **Meaning-conferral argument (the pivot)**: a motive moves me only through the meaning I confer; so no motive precedes freedom -> determinism refuted. - **Three moods**: anguish (*angoisse*, before my freedom), abandonment (*délaissement*, no God/values), despair (*desespoir*, no guarantee).
- **"In choosing myself I choose man"** - quasi-Kantian universalisation; source of anguish's weight. - **Situated freedom**: absolute in the field of meaning, not physically unlimited; later *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) concedes scarcity/seriality/practico-inert.
- **Trap**: asserting "radical freedom" without the meaning-conferral step; ignoring the later concession. - **Practice link**: MCQs 13-16; PYQ 2019 Q4(c), 2020 Q4(a), 2021 Q4(b).

RAPID REVISION 5 - Sartre II - Bad Faith, Facticity/Transcendence, and the Pour-soi / En-soi Ontology

Rapid recall

- **en-soi** = being-in-itself: full, solid, self-identical, "it is what it is," no consciousness. **pour-soi** = being-for-itself: consciousness, nihilating, "it is what it is not and is not what it is." - **Bad faith (mauvaise foi)** = self-deception that identifies with **facticity only** (the over-scripted waiter) or **transcendence only** (the woman on the date), fleeing freedom. Not lying to others; a single pre-reflective posture. - **Facticity** (given: body, past, situation) vs **transcendence** (freedom to surpass) - bad faith denies one half. - **Paradox** solved by non-self-identity (no Freudian unconscious needed). - **Nihilation (neantisation)**: the pour-soi secretes nothingness; "the being by which nothingness comes into the world." - **Impossible synthesis**: pour-soi craves to be *pour-soi-en-soi* (= God); contradictory -> **"man is a useless passion."**
- **Trap**: *en-soi* = matter and *pour-soi* = mind (wrong - it is an ontological, not mind-matter, distinction).
- **Practice link**: MCQs 17-20; PYQ 2023 Q3(c), 2025 Q1(c); feeds 2018 Q1(d).

RAPID REVISION 6 - Sartre III - The Look (le regard), Being-for-Others, Shame, and the Conflict of Recognition

Rapid recall

- **Third dimension**: being-for-others (*l'être-pour-autrui*), Part III of *Being and Nothingness* - not just in-itself/for-itself.
- **The Look (le regard)** objectifies me; the **keyhole**: absorbed (no ego) -> seen -> **shame (la honte)** = recognition "I am as the Other sees me."
- **The Other = "the indispensable mediator between myself and me"**; not reached by inference (contra Husserl's appresentation). My being-for-others is an outside I cannot control - the "original fall" into objecthood. - **Recognition fails both ways**: possess the free look (love, masochism) or reduce to object (sadism, hate) -> **"conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others."**
- **"L'enfer, c'est les autres"** (*Huis clos*, 1944) - quote, then correct: twisted relations, and the dead are fixed.
- **Compare**: Husserl (appresentation) / Heidegger (*Mitsein*) / Sartre (the Look) / Levinas (the face). Levinas is the strongest objection.
- **Practice link**: MCQs 21-24; PYQ 2018 Q1(d).

RAPID REVISION 7 - Heidegger I - Dasein and Being-in-the-World: Worldhood, Equipment, the Existentialia and Care

Rapid recall

- **Dasein** = being-there; the entity whose own Being is an issue and who understands Being. - **Being-in-the-world (In-der-Welt-sein)** = one unitary phenomenon; dissolves the Cartesian subject/object split; **not** spatial containment. - **Worldhood** = referential web of meaning (in-order-to, *Um-zu*), not the sum of objects.
 - **Ready-to-hand (Zuhandenheit)** = equipment used, absorbed; **present-at-hand (Vorhandenheit)** = detached object of theory, **derived**. The **broken hammer** shows theory presupposes practice. - **Existentialia**: *Befindlichkeit* (attunement) + *Verstehen* (understanding/projection) + *Rede* (discourse) = **disclosedness**. - **Care (Sorge)** = "ahead-of-itself -- already-in -- alongside"; ontological, not psychological worry. - **Provenance**: *Being and Time* (1927) is unfinished; cite by section. *Epoche* in 2018 Q4(a) is Husserl's method - attribute correctly, keep Phenomenology parts separate.
 - **Practice link**: MCQs 25-28; PYQ 2018 Q4(a), 2022 Q2(a).
-

RAPID REVISION 8 - Heidegger II - Authenticity and Inauthenticity: das Man, Falling, the Call of Conscience and Being-toward-Death

Rapid recall

- **Authenticity (Eigentlichkeit)** is **NOT** a moral virtue; inauthenticity is **NOT** a failing. Both are ontological modes; Dasein is inauthentic "proximally and for the most part" (structural). - **das Man ("the they")**: anonymous public self; marks = **idle talk (Gerede)**, **curiosity (Neugier)**, **ambiguity (Zweideutigkeit)**. **Falling (Verfallen)** = absorbed dispersal.
 - **Call of conscience (Ruf des Gewissens)**: silent, contentless; summons Dasein back to its ownmost potentiality.
 - **Being-toward-death (Sein-zum-Tode)**: ownmost, non-relational, certain, indefinite (O-N-C-I). Not the empirical event; it individualises.
 - **Anticipatory resoluteness (vorlaufende Entschlossenheit)**: own finitude -> gather existence into a whole.
 - **Deepest objection**: authenticity is **formally empty** (no content) - "a Nazi could be authentic"; Adorno's "jargon of authenticity," Heidegger's 1933, Levinas, Arendt. - **Trap**: authenticity = moral goodness; being-toward-death = fearing death or suicide. - **Practice link**: MCQs 29-32; PYQ 2019 Q3(a), 2022 Q2(a).
-

RAPID REVISION 9 - Heidegger III - Temporality (Zeitlichkeit): the Three Ecstases, Future-Priority, and Primordial versus Vulgar Time

Rapid recall

- **Temporality (Zeitlichkeit)** = the **meaning of Care** (Division Two of *Being and Time*); not clock-time.
 - **Three ecstases**: **future (Zukunft)**, primary - projection, being-toward-death -> having-been (*Gewesenheit* - thrownness) -> present (*Gegenwart* - making-present). Map to Care: ahead-of-itself / already-in / alongside.
 - **Ecstatic** (ek-stasis, "standing out"), a **unity, finite** (bounded by death); the future leads and temporalises the rest - authenticity is **futural**. - **Primordial vs vulgar time**: the infinite **now-series** (clock time) is a **derived, levelled-down** form arising from falling; primordial time is ecstatic and finite. - **Historicality (Geschichtlichkeit)**: Dasein is intrinsically historical; history is *how Dasein is*.
 - **Provenance**: Division III ("Time and Being") never published; later the *Kehre* (turn).
 - **Trap**: treating the ecstases as segments of a line, or temporality as clock-time. - **Practice link**: MCQs 33-36; PYQ 2019 Q3(a).
-

RAPID REVISION 10 - Comparison and Answer Spine - Fear versus Angst across the Three Thinkers, and the Cross-Thinker Synthesis

Rapid recall

- **Fear vs anxiety** differ in **object**, not degree: fear = a definite thing in the world (I flee toward the world); anxiety/dread/anguish = **no definite object** ("a nothing"), which **individualises** and discloses freedom/finitude - a **privileged mood**. - **What each says it is about**: Kierkegaard - my **possibility of freedom**; Heidegger - **Being-in-the-world as such**; Sartre - my own **freedom**. - **Three examples**: Kierkegaard's **dizziness of freedom** (Vigilius Haufniensis, 1844); Heidegger's **"complete insignificance"** (*Being and Time* s.40); Sartre's **cliff path + gambler**. - **Naturalist objection** (anxiety = pathology) answered by making the *objectlessness* itself the datum.
- **Answer spine**: orient (shared conviction + 3-way split) -> decode directive -> named source/example -> objection/reply -> graded verdict. "Existentialism" is a **family**, not a school. - **Trap**: "anxiety is a stronger fear" (wrong - it is objectless and disclosive). - **Practice link**: MCQs 37-40; closes every PYQ answer.

CANONICAL EXAM APPARATUS (PRESERVED VERBATIM)

The examiner apparatus below is reproduced verbatim from the canonical Existentialism.md (headings demoted, navigation links stripped). It is preserved intact so that no canonical depth - criticisms and replies, common traps, the keyword and statement bank, the restored 2018/2020 dossier, the corpus depth delta, PYQ routing, answer architecture, inter-thinker debates, the directive decoder, the graded verdict bank, translation / quotation / provenance discipline, link-outs and sources - is lost in the layered reorganisation.

Criticisms and Replies

4.1 Criticisms of Sartre

Criticism	Source	Reply / Counter
Radical freedom is psychologically implausible - people under extreme oppression (slavery, torture, mental illness) are not "absolutely free"	Common sense; Marxist tradition (Merleau-Ponty, <i>Adventures of the Dialectic</i>)	Sartre distinguishes freedom-of-consciousness (always present - I can always <i>interpret</i>) from freedom-of-action (limited by situation). But this weakens the radical thesis. In the <i>Critique of Dialectical Reason</i> (1960), Sartre himself integrates scarcity, seriality, and the "practico-inert" - acknowledging material constraints far more than in <i>Being and Nothingness</i> . ANALYSIS:
Bad faith presupposes what it denies - to deceive myself, I must both know and not know the truth; but Sartre rejects the Freudian unconscious. How is self-deception possible for a fully transparent consciousness?	Analytic philosophy of mind (Fingarette, <i>Self-Deception</i>)	Sartre's answer: the pour-soi's non-self-identity allows a <i>pre-reflective</i> awareness that is not <i>thetically</i> posited - I "know" at the pre-reflective level but do not reflectively avow it. Whether this is coherent remains debated. CAUTION:
Choice without criteria is blind - if there are no <i>a priori</i> values, on what basis do I choose? Sartre's freedom risks becoming <i>arbitrary</i> (existentialist "decisionism")	Iris Murdoch, <i>The Sovereignty of Good</i> ; Marxist critics	Sartre replies that the very <i>engagement</i> of choice generates its own criteria - but critics find this circular.
The universalisability requirement (§2.5) sits uneasily with the denial of objective values	Kantians, communitarians	Sartre concedes tension; the later <i>Notebooks for an Ethics</i> (posthumous) attempts a more substantive ethics but was never completed. CAUTION:

4.2 Criticisms of Heidegger

Criticism	Source	Reply / Counter
Obscurity - <i>Being and Time</i> is deliberately obscure; neologisms obstruct rather than clarify	Carnap (1932), Ayer, Russell, analytic tradition generally	Heidegger: ordinary language is saturated with the metaphysical tradition; new terms are needed to <i>break through</i> to the phenomena themselves. Whether this justifies the opacity is contested. CAUTION:
Fundamental ontology never delivered its second half - Division III of <i>Being and Time</i> (Time and Being) was never published; the project was abandoned	Internal	Heidegger acknowledged this and underwent the "turn" (<i>Kehre</i>) - moving from Dasein-analytic toward the history of Being, language, and art. Whether this is a failure or a deepening is debated. CAUTION:
Authenticity is formally empty - it prescribes no <i>content</i> ; a Nazi could be "authentic"	Political critics (given Heidegger's own 1933 complicity)	Heidegger: authenticity is deliberately non-prescriptive; it does not tell you <i>what</i> to choose, only <i>how</i> - owning your existence. But many find this ethically irresponsible. ANALYSIS:
Being-toward-death is morbid / excludes positive social bonds	Emmanuel Levinas (ethics of the Other), Hannah Arendt (natality over mortality)	Heidegger: death is not morbidity but the disclosure of finitude that makes <i>any</i> authentic engagement possible - including care for others. But Levinas's alternative (the face of the Other as primary) remains a powerful counter. ANALYSIS:

4.3 Criticisms of Kierkegaard

Criticism	Source	Reply / Counter
Fideism / irrationalism - the "leap of faith" abandons rationality; this is intellectually irresponsible	Hegel (implicitly), analytic philosophy of religion	Kierkegaard: the <i>point</i> is that rationality cannot encompass the existential truth of faith. Reason is not <i>wrong</i> but <i>limited</i> - it cannot deliver what the religious individual needs. Whether this is a reductio of Kierkegaard or a valid critique of rationalism depends on one's epistemology. CAUTION:
Elitism of the individual - by elevating the singular individual over the community, Kierkegaard undermines ethics and social responsibility	Communitarian critics, Hegelians	Kierkegaard: the "crowd is untruth" precisely because it enables ethical evasion; genuine responsibility requires the individual to stand alone (before God or before the ethical demand).
"Truth is subjectivity" collapses into relativism	Common misreading	Standard reply: Kierkegaard distinguishes <i>what</i> is believed from <i>how</i> it is believed. "Truth is subjectivity" concerns the <i>mode of appropriation</i> , not the propositional content. He does not deny objective truth for logic/science; he denies its <i>sufficiency</i> for existential/religious truth. ANALYSIS:

Common UPSC Traps

Trap	Correction
"Existence precedes essence" is shared by all three	Wrong. It is Sartre's slogan. Heidegger explicitly disowned it as a humanistic misreading. Kierkegaard never used this phrase.
Kierkegaard's "truth is subjectivity" = relativism	Wrong. It concerns the <i>mode of appropriation</i> (passionate inwardness), not a denial of objective truth.

Trap	Correction
Heidegger's authenticity = moral goodness	Wrong. It is a formal/ontological modification of everydayness, not a moral category. An inauthentic person is not morally bad; an authentic one is not morally good.
Sartre's <i>en-soi</i> = "matter" and <i>pour-soi</i> = "mind"	Wrong. En-soi is being-that-is-what-it-is (self-identical); pour-soi is being-that-is-not-what-it-is (nihilating consciousness). This is an <i>ontological</i> , not a mind-matter, distinction.
Sartre and Heidegger agree on freedom	Wrong. Sartre's freedom is <i>absolute</i> and centred on the choosing <i>subject</i> . Heidegger's is <i>ontological</i> - Dasein is <i>thrown projection</i> , but this is about Being's disclosure, not voluntaristic self-creation.
Kierkegaard's stages are chronological/developmental	Misleading. They are <i>qualitative spheres</i> , not temporal stages. One does not "grow out of" the aesthetic by maturation; one <i>leaps</i> . And relapse is always possible.
Heidegger's "being-toward-death" = contemplating suicide or fearing death	Wrong. It is the disclosure of death as one's <i>ownmost possibility</i> - it individualises and frees Dasein for authentic existence. It is NOT about the empirical event of dying.

Keyword and Statement Bank

#	Term / Statement	Thinker	Significance
1	FACT: "Existence precedes essence"	Sartre	No fixed human nature; man is a self-making project
2	FACT: "Man is condemned to be free"	Sartre	Freedom is inescapable; it is our being, not a property
3	FACT: "In choosing myself I choose man"	Sartre	Choice implies universal legislation (quasi-Kantian)
4	FACT: "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is"	Sartre	Non-self-identity of the pour-soi via nihilation
5	FACT: "Hell is other people" (<i>Huis Clos</i>)	Sartre	The Look (<i>le regard</i>) - the Other objectifies me
6	FACT: "Truth is subjectivity"	Kierkegaard	Mode of appropriation > objective content for existential truth
7	FACT: "The crowd is untruth"	Kierkegaard	Authentic existence requires standing alone
8	FACT: "The essence of Dasein lies in its existence"	Heidegger	Dasein's "what" = its "how" - its manner of being
9	FACT: "Ahead-of-itself - already-in - alongside"	Heidegger	Formal structure of Care (<i>Sorge</i>)
10	FACT: <i>Sein-zum-Tode</i> (being-toward-death)	Heidegger	Death as ownmost, non-relational, certain possibility
11	FACT: <i>Das Man</i> ("the they")	Heidegger	Anonymous public self - source of inauthenticity
12	FACT: Teleological suspension of the ethical	Kierkegaard	Abraham: faith overrides the universal moral law
13	ANALYSIS: Pour-soi = nihilation; en-soi = plenitude	Sartre	The ontological dualism of <i>Being and Nothingness</i>
14	ANALYSIS: "Shepherd of Being" (Letter on Humanism)	Heidegger	Man is not the lord of beings but the guardian of Being

Restored 2018 / 2020 Doctrine Dossier

Sartre: bad faith, inauthenticity and alienation

- FACT: Bad faith is the project of treating oneself as only facticity or only transcendence in order to flee responsibility. Inauthenticity follows because consciousness denies its own unstable freedom; alienation follows when the self lives through fixed social roles or the objectifying look.
- FACT: **Canonical examples:** the over-scripted waiter and the person who postpones recognising the meaning of another's gesture. - CAUTION: **Objection -> reply:** radical freedom can ignore oppression and circumstance. Sartre's reply appeals to situated freedom: one always chooses from a factual situation, not from nowhere.

Heidegger against the transcendental ego

- **FACT:** Epoché begins from a reflective suspension, whereas Heidegger argues that the more primordial condition is Dasein's already-involved being-in-the-world. Subject and object are derivative abstractions from practical involvement.
- **ANALYSIS:** Heidegger does not merely reject careful phenomenological description; he redirects it from transcendental consciousness to the disclosedness of Being through care, equipment and temporality.
- **WRONG:** Do not equate being-in-the-world with spatial containment or with Sartrean consciousness.

Corpus-Driven Depth Delta

- **ANALYSIS: Priority:** Primary ownership rises to 14 of 112 parts, joint-highest, with at least one part in every year.
- **FACT: Required doctrinal depth:** The restored papers add Sartrean inauthenticity-bad faith-alienation, Heidegger's rejection of transcendental reduction through being-in-the-world, Kierkegaard's single individual and Sartre's facticity-transcendence formula.
- **WRONG: Trap / answer consequence:** Do not merge Heidegger's critique of the transcendental ego with Sartrean bad faith; state each thinker's problem, ontology of the agent and criterion of authenticity.

PYQ Routing Table

ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: 14 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q1(d)	10 marks	How does Sartre connect inauthenticity with bad faith? Why does Sartre show that inauthenticity and bad faith lead to alienation? Discuss.
2018	Q4(a)	20 marks	What is 'Epoché'? How does Heidegger reject this method of phenomenological reduction? Explain Heidegger's concept of 'being in the world' as opposed to the concept of a transcendental ego.
2019	Q3(a)	20 marks	Is Dasein authentic existence for Heidegger? How does he relate temporality with Dasein? Discuss.
2019	Q4(c)	15 marks	How does Sartre look at the problem of freedom of choice and determinism? Explain.
2020	Q3(a)	20 marks	What does Kierkegaard mean by saying "Subjectivity is the truth" in the context of the problem of 'the single individual'?
2020	Q4(a)	20 marks	"You can always make something out of what you have been made into." Critically discuss this statement by Sartre with reference to his views on existentialism.
2021	Q4(b)	15 marks	"I can always choose, but I ought to know that if I do not choose, I am still choosing". Critically discuss Sartre's conception of choice and responsibility in the light of above statement.
2022	Q2(a)	20 marks	Provide a critical account of Heidegger's Being-in-the-world and discuss the problem of 'authenticity' in the context of Dasein.
2022	Q4(a)	20 marks	How does Soren Kierkegaard define the notion of 'subjectivity'? Explain it with reference to three stages of existence as propounded by him.
2023	Q1(d)	10 marks	How does Kierkegaard argue against Hegel's idea of universal spirit in favour of the individual as the essence of spirit? Critically discuss.
2023	Q3(c)	15 marks	"Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is." In the light of this statement bring out the chief features of Sartre's conception of consciousness.
2024	Q1(e)	10 marks	How does Kierkegaard define truth in terms of subjectivity? Critically discuss.
2024	Q4(a)	20 marks	What do the existentialist thinkers mean by the slogan "existence precedes essence"? How is human existence related to human freedom according to them? Discuss.
2025	Q1(c)	10 marks	Explain the difference between being-for-itself and being-in-itself as presented by Sartre.

See the Western Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018-2025.

Answer Architecture Templates

8.1 - PYQ 2025 Q1(c) 10m: "Explain the difference between pour-soi and en-soi."

Defn : En-soi (being-in-itself) = being that is what it is - full, self-identical, opaque, without consciousness. Pour-soi (being-for-itself) = being that is not what it is and is not what it is - consciousness, nihilation, self-surpassing.

Body : En-soi: solid, complete, non-relational (a stone simply IS). Pour-soi: introduces nothingness - questions, negates, projects beyond the given. Constituted by freedom. Key formula: consciousness "is what it is not" (projects toward a future it doesn't have) and "is not what it is" (transcends its facticity/past).

Close : The pour-soi perpetually seeks to become en-soi (self-identical) - to be a "for-itself-in-itself" (= God) - but this is a contradictory ideal. Human reality is defined by this impossible desire: hence "man is a useless passion."

8.2 - PYQ 2024 Q4(a) 10+10m: "Existence precedes essence + freedom."

Frame : The central existentialist reversal of the Western tradition.

Part 1 : The paper-knife analogy (Sartre): essence (design) precedes existence for artefacts; but there is no divine artisan for man -> existence first, essence self-created. Kierkegaard: the System (Hegel) cannot account for the existing individual. Heidegger: "the essence of Dasein lies in its existence" - but rejects the humanist reading (Letter on Humanism).

Part 2 : Freedom - if no fixed essence, man is radically free (Sartre). "Condemned to be free" - freedom is inescapable, total, accompanied by anguish. Responsibility follows: in choosing, I choose an image of man (quasi-Kantian universalisability). Heidegger: freedom = Dasein's projection upon possibilities (not voluntarism). Kierkegaard: freedom is real but bounded - the leap presupposes that one CAN choose.

Assess : The primacy of existence over essence empowers a radical ethics of responsibility; but critics ask whether ungrounded freedom can generate actual values without collapsing into decisionism.

8.3 - PYQ 2023 Q3(c) 15m: "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is."

Frame : This formula captures Sartre's ontology of the pour-soi - human consciousness as constitutively non-self-identical, in contrast to the en-soi (which IS what it IS).

Body A : "Is what it is not" - consciousness is always AHEAD of itself, projecting toward possibilities not yet realised. It IS defined by its future (which does not yet exist).

Body B : "Is not what it is" - consciousness CANNOT coincide with its facticity/past. The waiter "is" a waiter but simultaneously "is not" - he transcends the role.

Body C : How this is possible: NIHILATION (néantisation). The pour-soi secretes nothingness; it stands back from what is (questions, negates, imagines alternatives).

Assess : This accounts for freedom, bad faith, and the perpetual restlessness of consciousness. Criticism: is "non-self-identity" coherent, or is it a contradiction dressed up in phenomenological language?

Close : The formula is the key to Sartre's entire system - it grounds freedom, bad faith, temporality, and the "useless passion" of the pour-soi's desire to be en-soi.

8.4 - PYQ 2022 Q2(a) 20m: "Being-in-the-world and authenticity."

Frame : Being-in-the-world is the fundamental constitution of Dasein; authenticity is a modification *within* that structure, not an escape from it.

Body A : Being-in-the-world as unitary - dissolves subject/object split. Worldhood: ready-to-hand (equipment, referential totality) vs present-at-hand (theoretical staring, derived). Existentialia: Befindlichkeit (attunement), Verstehen (understanding/projection), Rede (discourse). Care (Sorge) as the structural whole.

Body B : Das Man - falling into anonymous publicness. Idle talk, curiosity, ambiguity. Inauthenticity as Dasein's default.

Body C : Authenticity - call of conscience + being-toward-death -> anticipatory resoluteness. NOT a moral category - a formal modification of everydayness (owning one's thrown projection). Authenticity does not take Dasein OUT of the world; it lets Dasein be in-the-world in a way that is *owned*, not dispersed.

Crit : Formally empty (no content); Levinas - primacy of the Other, not death; political danger of content-free authenticity (Heidegger's own complicity).

Close : Being-in-the-world is the *what*; authenticity is the *how* - how Dasein takes up its always-already world-involvement.

8.5 - PYQ 2022 Q4(a) 20m: "Kierkegaard's subjectivity + three stages."

Frame : Kierkegaard's "truth is subjectivity" is his counter to Hegel's objective System.

Body A : Subjectivity ≠ relativism. It is about the MODE of appropriation - infinite passionate inwardness, existential commitment, risk. The how > the what for existential/religious truth.

Body B : Three stages - Aesthetic (pleasure, irony → despair); Ethical (universal duty, commitment → guilt); Religious (faith, the absurd, standing before God → paradox). The movement between them: the LEAP - not logical, not dialectical, but decisional.

Body C : Against Hegel: Hegel resolves everything into the System; Kierkegaard insists that the existing individual (den Enkele) can never be sublated into the universal. Spirit = the individual's self-relation, not Absolute Spirit.

Assess : Powerful critique of impersonal systematic philosophy; but risks fideism (abandoning rational accountability) and elitism (who can make the leap?).

Close : For Kierkegaard, the three stages trace a path of intensifying inwardness - from dispersion (aesthetic) through duty (ethical) to the "absolute relation to the Absolute" (religious). Subjectivity IS this intensification.

8.6 - PYQ 2021 Q4(b) 15m: "If I do not choose, I am still choosing."

Frame : Sartre's claim that freedom is inescapable - even non-choice is choice.

Body A : Radical freedom: the pour-soi cannot NOT choose (its being = freedom/nihilation). Not choosing (deferring, conforming, "waiting") is itself a choice - a choice to let circumstances or others decide, which is bad faith (pretending I am not free).

Body B : Responsibility follows: since all my states are freely sustained, I bear total responsibility. "There are no excuses" - I cannot blame passion, upbringing, or circumstance.

Body C : "In choosing myself I choose man" - universal dimension of choice.

Crit : Is the distinction between choosing-not-to-choose and genuinely being unable to choose real? Structural oppression (poverty, coercion) seems to limit not just action but awareness of alternatives. Sartre's later Marxist turn partly concedes this.

Close : The statement dramatises the inescapability of freedom - we are "condemned to be free" not as a punishment but as an ontological structure.

8.7 - PYQ 2019 Q3(a) 20m: "Is Dasein authentic existence? Temporality and Dasein."

Frame : Dasein is NOT defined as "authentic existence" - authenticity is one *modification* of Dasein's being. Dasein is mostly inauthentic (das Man, falling), and this is not a deficiency but a structural feature.

Body A : Dasein's being = Care (ahead-of-itself-already-in-alongside). Authenticity = owning this structure through anticipatory resoluteness (being-toward-death + call of conscience).

Body B : Temporality - the *meaning* of Care. Three ecstases: future (projection), having-been (thrownness), present (making-present). Future has primacy - anticipation of death gathers Dasein into a whole and enables authentic historicity.

Body C : Primordial temporality vs vulgar time: the "now-series" is a derivative, levelled-down form. Authentic temporality is ecstatic and finite (bounded by death).

Crit : Division III (Time and Being) never published - the project remains incomplete. Sartre: temporality grounds freedom (not just formal ontology). Levinas: death individualises excessively - what about the temporality of the Other?

Close : Dasein is not "authentic existence" but the entity whose being (Care) is temporal and which CAN exist authentically - by owning its finitude.

8.8 - PYQ 2019 Q4(c) 15m: "Sartre on freedom and determinism."

Frame : Sartre denies ALL forms of determinism - causal, psychological, social.

Body A : The pour-soi is constituted by nihilation/transcendence - it can always negate any given situation, interpret it anew, project beyond it. A "motive" has force only insofar as the pour-soi freely constitutes it as a motive.

Body B : "There are no excuses" - passion does not cause action (I choose to surrender to passion); circumstance does not fix me (I choose its meaning). Freedom is absolute *within the field of meaning*.

Body C : Limitation: Sartre acknowledges "situation" (facticity) - but insists freedom operates *within* situation, not *despite* it. I cannot fly, but I am free to interpret my inability and to project alternatives.

Crit : Psychologically implausible (mental illness, extreme coercion); socially blind (structural oppression). Sartre's later Critique of Dialectical Reason integrates material constraints (practico-inert, seriality) - a significant self-revision.

Close : For Sartre, the "problem" of freedom and determinism is a false problem: determinism misunderstands the pour-soi by treating it as en-soi (a thing among causes).

Inter-Thinker Debates

Axis	Kierkegaard	Sartre	Heidegger
God	Central - faith in the absurd, the God-relation	Denied - atheism as <i>premise</i>	Bracketed - ontology, not theology
Core term for human being	Den Enkelte (the individual, the single one)	Pour-soi (for-itself, nihilating consciousness)	Dasein (being-there, the entity that questions Being)
Path to authenticity	Leap of faith -> religious stage	Owning radical freedom, rejecting bad faith	Anticipatory resoluteness (being-toward-death)
Freedom	Real but finite; bounded by the God-relation and the "given" of creation	Absolute, total, inescapable - consciousness IS freedom	Ontological: Dasein's thrown projection; NOT voluntaristic self-creation
Temporality	Existence as <i>repetition</i> and <i>moment</i> (<i>Øjeblikket</i>) - the eternal entering time	Pour-soi as ecstatic (past/present/future); freedom nihilates the past	Zeitlichkeit - three ecstases, future-primacy, finite
Chief enemy	Hegel's System, the crowd, objective Christianity	Determinism, bad faith, the serious spirit	Cartesian dualism, <i>das Man</i> , metaphysics of presence
Relation to Hegel	Revolt - the individual cannot be sublated	Inherits dialectic (en-soi/pour-soi); rejects teleology	Inherits concern with Being; rejects Hegel's "ontotheology"
Mood disclosing truth	Anxiety (<i>Angest</i>), despair	Anguish (<i>angoisse</i>), nausea (<i>la nausée</i>)	Anxiety (<i>Angst</i>) - discloses the nothing/throwness

Directive Decoder

Directive	What it demands	Structural obligation for this file	Fatal error
Comment / Elucidate the statement (2021 "if I do not choose, I am still choosing"; 2023 "consciousness is what it is not")	locate the sentence in its own thinker's system , then unpack the technical terms	Identify the work, the pair of terms it turns on (pour-soi/en-soi, facticity/transcendence), then two consequences, then a judgment.	Treating the sentence as a general maxim about life.
Discuss existence precedes essence	show that it follows from atheism plus intentionality , not from rhetoric	Sartre's own argument: no God => no human nature conceived in advance => man first exists, then defines himself. Then the counter that Heidegger rejected the formula for himself.	Quoting the slogan and illustrating with a paper-knife only.
Critically examine authenticity (2019, 2022)	assessment dominates, and the non-moral reading is the marked point	State that <i>Eigentlichkeit</i> is an existential modification, not a virtue; then <i>das Man</i> , call of conscience, being-toward-death; then the charge of formal emptiness.	Treating authenticity as "being true to yourself."
Discuss being-in-the-world (2022, 20m)	the hyphens are the doctrine - show that the compound resists decomposition	Refuse the subject/object split first, then <i>Zuhandenheit/Vorhandenheit</i> , the broken hammer, care (<i>Sorge</i>), and only then temporality.	Describing Dasein as "a human being in the world."
How does Kierkegaard oppose Hegel?	a structural opposition, not a list of complaints	The existing individual vs the system; either/or vs both/and; the leap vs mediation; indirect communication vs the lecture. Add "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible."	"Kierkegaard disliked abstraction."
Explain freedom and determinism in Sartre (2019)	show why no motive determines , via meaning-conferral	Motives are motives only through the meaning the pour-soi confers; therefore no motive operates prior to freedom. Then the Marxist objection and the <i>Critique's</i> concession.	Asserting "radical freedom" without the meaning-conferral step.
Bring out the difference between fear and dread/anxiety	a structural difference in the object, and the disclosive payoff	§2.9's table plus one canonical example from each of the three thinkers.	Calling anxiety "a stronger kind of fear."

Directive	What it demands	Structural obligation for this file	Fatal error
Assess / Do you agree?	a defended ruling in the first line	Rule on radical freedom, on whether authenticity has content, or on whether conflict is really the basic relation with others.	Neutral survey.

Graded Verdict Bank

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
Existence precedes essence	The formula is a consequence of consistent atheism: with no maker, there is no design, and therefore no human nature settled in advance of living.	...It is Sartre's, not existentialism's: Heidegger repudiated the formula in the <i>Letter on Humanism</i> (1947), and Kierkegaard, a Christian, has no use for it. Handle "existentialism" as a family, not a school.	The doctrine's force is that it makes evasion impossible: since nothing is given, every appeal to nature, role or circumstance is itself a choice. Its cost is that it can give no account of <i>why</i> one project is better than another - a difficulty Sartre acknowledged and never resolved, since the promised ethics of <i>Being and Nothingness</i> was never written.
Radical freedom	Freedom is not a property the self has but what the self <i>is</i> ; situations limit what is possible, never what is chosen.	...The pivot is meaning-conferral: a motive becomes a motive only through the sense the pour-soi gives it, so nothing can move me prior to my freedom.	The doctrine is unfalsifiable as stated, and its author came to think so: the <i>Critique of Dialectical Reason</i> (1960) reintroduces scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert precisely to explain how freedom can be <i>conditioned</i> without being abolished. The defensible residue is not "we are absolutely free" but "there is no situation whose meaning is settled independently of an act of freedom" - and that is enough to defeat determinism without absurdity.
Bad faith	Bad faith is not lying to others but a single pre-reflective posture in which one identifies with facticity alone, or transcendence alone.	...Its possibility depends on the non-self-identity of consciousness - "it is what it is not and is not what it is" - which is why Sartre needs the whole ontology of the pour-soi to make self-deception intelligible.	Bad faith is Sartre's most successful concept because it is the only account of self-deception that does not require splitting the self into deceiver and deceived. Its difficulty is normative: if all consciousness is non-self-identical, what distinguishes bad faith from ordinary living? Sartre's answer, "authenticity," is gestured at in a footnote and never developed - so the concept diagnoses brilliantly and prescribes nothing.
The Look / being-for-others	The Other is not inferred but revealed as the one for whom I am an object; shame is the proof.	...This is a genuine advance on Husserl's appresentation, because the Other is encountered as a <i>subject</i> , not constituted as a sense.	The doctrine converts an insight about shame into a general theory of conflict by way of one premise - that being-subject and being-object are exclusive. Drop the premise and love, trust and solidarity become possible without ceasing to be relations to a free Other; keep it and "hell is other people" follows. Sartre's own group-in-fusion, and Levinas's ethics of the face, are two different ways of dropping it, which is the strongest evidence that it should be dropped.

Sub-topic	10-mark verdict	15-mark verdict	20-mark verdict
Anguish / fear	Fear has a determinate object within the world; anxiety has none, and that is why it discloses freedom rather than a threat.	...The three canonical cases are Kierkegaard's dizziness of freedom, Heidegger's collapse of significance, and Sartre's cliff and gambler; each shows the same structure with a different emphasis.	Anxiety is the tradition's methodological instrument: it is the one mood in which the totality of one's existence becomes an issue, and therefore the only phenomenon that can motivate an existential analytic. The naturalist reply - that anxiety is a pathological state with no cognitive credentials - is answerable only by insisting that the mood's objectlessness is itself the datum, and no reductive account of that objectlessness has succeeded.
Authenticity (Heidegger)	<i>Eigentlichkeit</i> is an existential modification, not a moral achievement; Dasein is inauthentic proximally and for the most part, and this is structural.	...Anticipatory resoluteness gives Dasein its ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite possibility, and thereby a whole - but it prescribes no content whatever.	The formality is deliberate and it is the doctrine's deepest problem. Adorno's charge of a "jargon of authenticity," and the political catastrophe of Heidegger's own 1933, both press the same question: a criterion that tells you to own your choices without telling you which to make can dignify any resolute commitment. The defence - that fundamental ontology is not ethics - is textually correct and philosophically unsatisfying.
Kierkegaard vs Hegel	The system can contain everything except the one who builds it: "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible."	...Hence either/or against both/and, the leap against mediation, and indirect communication against the lecture - a total opposition of form as well as content.	The opposition is genuine but not symmetrical: Kierkegaard defeats Hegel on the ground of the individual and cannot compete on the ground of system, which he does not want. What makes the critique permanent is that it is <i>internal</i> to the Hegelian achievement - Kierkegaard attacks precisely at the Unhappy Consciousness, where Hegel had already located the diagnosis and claimed a cure. See Hegel's <i>md</i> §1.8.
Indirect communication	Because ethical-religious truth is a mode of existing and not a result, it can be communicated only in a form that withholds the result.	...Hence the pseudonyms are existence-possibilities, not disguises; cite them by name, as Kierkegaard's own "First and Last Declaration" asks.	The method is self-consuming - Climacus revokes the <i>Postscript</i> - and the cost is intended. That Kierkegaard, the early Wittgenstein and Hegel's Unhappy Consciousness all terminate in a text that discards itself is not coincidence: each is trying to communicate something that cannot survive being held as doctrine.

Translation, Quotation and Provenance Discipline

Three languages (Danish, German, French), three posthumous-edition problems, and one name-attribution rule.

Kierkegaard (Danish)

Item	Status	Practice
Pseudonyms	See §2B	FACT: Cite the pseudonym: "Johannes de Silentio," "Climacus," "Vigilius Haufniensis," "Anti-Climacus." Kierkegaard printed a request to this effect in the "First and Last Declaration" appended to the <i>Postscript</i> (1846).
Editions	Hong & Hong , <i>Kierkegaard's Writings</i> (Princeton, 1978-2000) - the scholarly standard; Walter Lowrie (1940s) - the older translations still reprinted in India; Alastair Hannay (Penguin)	ANALYSIS: Wording differs substantially. <i>Angest</i> is " dread " in Lowrie and " anxiety " in Hong; the book is <i>The Concept of Dread</i> (Lowrie) or <i>The Concept of Anxiety</i> (Hong). Name the translation or use the Danish once.
"Truth is subjectivity"	<i>Concluding Unscientific Postscript</i> (1846), by Climacus	FACT: Safe; attribute to Climacus.
"Anxiety is the dizziness of freedom"	<i>The Concept of Anxiety</i> (1844), by Vigilius Haufniensis	ANALYSIS: Lowrie: "dizziness of freedom"; renderings vary slightly. Safe as a rendering with the attribution.
"Leap of faith"	ANALYSIS: Provenance: Kierkegaard writes of <i>the leap</i> (<i>Springet</i>) and of faith; the fused phrase " leap of faith " is the English tradition's , not a literal translation of a Kierkegaardian term.	Write "the leap - what the English tradition calls the leap of faith."
"Life must be lived forwards but understood backwards"	From the journals , not a published work	ANALYSIS: Say "in his journals."
<i>The Point of View for My Work as an Author</i>	Written 1848 , published posthumously 1859	ANALYSIS: A retrospective self-interpretation; do not cite it as contemporaneous evidence of intention.

Heidegger (German)

Item	Status	Practice
<i>Sein und Zeit</i>	1927 ; ANALYSIS: Division Two of Part One only - the projected Part Two was never written.	FACT: Cite by § number (§26 <i>Mitsein</i> ; §§27, 35-38 <i>das Man</i> , <i>Gerede</i> , <i>Verfallen</i> ; §40 <i>Angst</i> ; §§46-53 being-toward-death; §§54-60 conscience; §65 temporality) - § numbers are edition- and translation-invariant. ANALYSIS: Never write "in <i>Being and Time</i> Heidegger completes his analysis of Being" - he does not; the book is unfinished.
Translations	Macquarrie & Robinson (1962) and Joan Stambaugh (1996, rev. Schmidt 2010)	ANALYSIS: Key differences: <i>Dasein</i> untranslated in both; <i>Befindlichkeit</i> = "state-of-mind" (M&R) vs "attunement" (Stambaugh); <i>das Man</i> = "the 'they'" (M&R) vs "the they" / "the anyone." Name the translation for any quoted phrase.
Untranslated terms	<i>Dasein</i> , <i>Zuhandenheit</i> , <i>Vorhandenheit</i> , <i>Geworfenheit</i> , <i>Sorge</i> , <i>das Man</i> , <i>Eigentlichkeit</i> , <i>Sein-zum-Tode</i> , <i>vorlaufende Entschlossenheit</i>	FACT: Give the German once with a gloss; this is standard and expected on this item.
"Nothing noths" (<i>Das Nichts nichtet</i>)	<i>Was ist Metaphysik?</i> (1929), Heidegger's Freiburg inaugural lecture	FACT: Correct renderings: " Nothing noths " / "the nothing nothings." WRONG: "Nothing noughts" is wrong and must not be used. See Logical-Positivism.md §T.

Item	Status	Practice
Repudiation of Sartre	<i>Brief über den Humanismus / Letter on Humanism (1946, published 1947)</i>	FACT: Essential for any "existentialism" answer: Heidegger explicitly denies that his thought is existentialism, and rejects the formula "existence precedes essence" as a metaphysical inversion that stays within metaphysics.

Sartre (French)

Item	Status	Practice
<i>L'Être et le Néant / Being and Nothingness</i>	1943 ; Eng. tr. Hazel Barnes (1956); newer Sarah Richmond (2018)	ANALYSIS: Barnes's renderings are the ones most Indian guides reproduce; Richmond revises many. Name the translation, or keep the French term.
Untranslated terms	<i>en-soi, pour-soi, pour-autrui, néantisation, mauvaise foi, facticité, le regard, angoisse, déréliction/délaissement</i>	FACT: Use the French once with a gloss.
<i>L'existentialisme est un humanisme</i>	Lecture October 1945 , published 1946 ; Eng. <i>Existentialism Is a Humanism</i>	ANALYSIS: It is a popular lecture , and Sartre later regretted publishing it. Slogans ("condemned to be free," "existence precedes essence," "man is nothing else but what he makes of himself") come from here , not from <i>Being and Nothingness</i> . Say so - it is a precision mark.
"L'enfer, c'est les autres"	<i>Huis clos (No Exit)</i> , play, 1944	FACT: Safe verbatim in French. ANALYSIS: Add Sartre's own correction of the popular reading (§2A(7)).
<i>Critique de la raison dialectique</i>	1960	FACT: Cite for the later concessions: scarcity, seriality, the practico-inert, the group-in-fusion.

WRONG: Never write: "the existentialists held that..." as though Kierkegaard, Heidegger and Sartre share a doctrine - Kierkegaard is a Christian, Heidegger denied he was an existentialist, and only Sartre accepted the label; that authenticity means being true to oneself; that *Being and Time* is a completed system; or that "leap of faith" is a phrase of Kierkegaard's.

Link-Outs to Related Topics

- Phenomenology-Husserl.md - the parent method; intentionality -> being-in-the-world; Heidegger was Husserl's student (dedicated *Being and Time* to him).
- Hegel.md - Kierkegaard's target (the individual vs the System); Sartre inherits dialectical structure.
- Kant.md - Sartre's quasi-Kantian universalisability; Kant on freedom and determinism (Third Antinomy - Heidegger inherits).
- Rationalism.md - Descartes' cogito and res cogitans - what Heidegger destroys by positing being-in-the-world.
- ../_themes/Critiques-of-metaphysics.md - existentialism's critique of essentialist/systematic metaphysics.
- ../_themes/Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md - Dasein vs ātman vs anātman; existential "liberation" (authenticity) vs mokṣa.
- ../indian/Vedanta.md - Advaita's "self is Brahman" vs existentialism's "no fixed self/essence."
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Reason-Revelation-Faith.md - Kierkegaard's leap of faith; religion-without-God angle for atheistic existentialism.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md - being-toward-death vs immortality.
- ../PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md - full PYQ bank.

Sources

- Sartre, Jean-Paul. *Being and Nothingness* (*L'Être et le Néant*, 1943) - pour-soi/en-soi, nihilation, bad faith, radical freedom.
- Sartre, Jean-Paul. *Existentialism is a Humanism* (*L'existentialisme est un humanisme*, 1946) - the public lecture: paper-knife, "condemned to be free," anguish/abandonment/despair.
- Sartre, Jean-Paul. *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) - the Marxist turn, scarcity, seriality.
- Heidegger, Martin. *Being and Time* (*Sein und Zeit*, 1927) - Dasein, being-in-the-world, Care, temporality, authenticity, being-toward-death.
- Heidegger, Martin. "Letter on Humanism" (1947) - rejection of Sartre's existentialism as humanistic metaphysics.
- Kierkegaard, Søren. *Either/Or* (1843) - aesthetic vs ethical stages.
- Kierkegaard, Søren. *Fear and Trembling* (1843) - Abraham, teleological suspension of the ethical, knight of faith.
- Kierkegaard, Søren. *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846) - truth is subjectivity, the existing individual vs the System.
- Masih, Y. *A Critical History of Western Philosophy* - chapters on Existentialism.
- Kenny, Anthony. *A New History of Western Philosophy*, Vol. 4 - Heidegger and Sartre sections.
- Copleston, Frederick. *A History of Philosophy*, Vols. 7 and 11
- Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Sartre.
- Warburton, Nigel. *Philosophy: The Classics* - Sartre and Heidegger chapters.

ORIGINAL MCQ MASTERY SET - EXACTLY 48 QUESTIONS

Questions 1-40 are core coverage - four per subtopic across the ten subtopics; Questions 41-48 are remedial items targeting the most common misreadings. Correct answers rotate strictly A -> B -> C -> D 12 times.

MCQ 1

The three existentialists Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger most fundamentally share:

- A. the primacy of concrete existence over any abstract system or fixed essence
B. a commitment to the centrality of God in authentic life
C. the doctrine that consciousness is a nihilating for-itself
D. the thesis that being-in-the-world is a unitary phenomenon

Correct answer: A - the primacy of concrete existence over any abstract system or fixed essence

Explanation: Their shared conviction is the primacy of the existing individual; the other three options are single-thinker doctrines (theism is only Kierkegaard's, the pour-soi only Sartre's, being-in-the-world only Heidegger's).

MCQ 2

Which pairing of thinker and orientation is correct?

- A. Kierkegaard - atheistic and freedom-centred
B. Sartre - atheistic and freedom-centred, against Kierkegaard's theistic anti-Hegelianism and Heidegger's ontological anti-humanism
C. Heidegger - theistic and anti-Hegelian
D. Kierkegaard - ontological and anti-humanist

Correct answer: B - Sartre - atheistic and freedom-centred, against Kierkegaard's theistic anti-Hegelianism and Heidegger's ontological anti-humanism

Explanation: Kierkegaard is theistic and anti-Hegelian; Sartre atheistic and freedom-centred; Heidegger ontological and anti-humanist. Only option B states the correct triad.

MCQ 3

The printed Paper I syllabus renders the second thinker's name as:

- A. 'Sartre', exactly as in his published works
B. 'Satre', a two-letter contraction
C. 'Sarte', a verbatim syllabus anomaly, although the philosopher is Jean-Paul Sartre
D. 'Sarthe', after the French department

Correct answer: C - 'Sarte', a verbatim syllabus anomaly, although the philosopher is Jean-Paul Sartre

Explanation: The UPSC syllabus prints 'Sarte'; it is preserved only as a verbatim syllabus quotation, while 'Sartre' is used correctly throughout the answer.

MCQ 4

The core term each thinker uses for the human being is:

A. Kierkegaard = Dasein B. Sartre = den Enkelte C. Heidegger = pour-soi D. Kierkegaard = den Enkelte, Sartre = pour-soi, Heidegger = Dasein

Correct answer: D - Kierkegaard = den Enkelte, Sartre = pour-soi, Heidegger = Dasein

Explanation: den Enkelte (the single individual) is Kierkegaard's; the pour-soi (for-itself) is Sartre's; Dasein (being-there) is Heidegger's. Only option D matches all three.

MCQ 5

Kierkegaard's claim that 'truth is subjectivity' means:

A. the mode of appropriation - passionate inwardness - is decisive for existential truth, not that objective truth is denied
B. all truth is relative to the individual's feelings
C. objective truth does not exist in any domain
D. truth is whatever the crowd collectively agrees upon

Correct answer: A - the mode of appropriation - passionate inwardness - is decisive for existential truth, not that objective truth is denied

Explanation: The claim (Climacus, Postscript, 1846) concerns the how of appropriation, not the what; Kierkegaard denies objective truth's sufficiency for existence, not its existence - so it is not relativism.

MCQ 6

Kierkegaard's three stages or spheres of existence are best described as:

A. chronological developmental phases one matures through
B. qualitative spheres - aesthetic, ethical, religious - joined by the leap, not by maturation
C. the aesthetic, the political and the religious
D. the Hegelian triad of thesis, antithesis and synthesis

Correct answer: B - qualitative spheres - aesthetic, ethical, religious - joined by the leap, not by maturation

Explanation: The stages are qualitative spheres, not temporal phases; one does not grow out of the aesthetic but leaps, and relapse is always possible.

MCQ 7

The 'teleological suspension of the ethical' is illustrated by:

A. the seducer's diary in Either/Or
B. Judge William's defence of marriage
C. Abraham's willingness to sacrifice Isaac in Fear and Trembling (by Johannes de Silentio)
D. Socratic irony as endless negativity

Correct answer: C - Abraham's willingness to sacrifice Isaac in Fear and Trembling (by Johannes de Silentio)

Explanation: Abraham, the knight of faith, suspends the universal ethical law for the absolute God-relation through infinite resignation and the double movement - the teleological suspension of the ethical.

MCQ 8

On indirect communication and pseudonymity, which statement is correct?

A. the pseudonyms are mere disguises adopted to evade censorship
B. Kierkegaard wanted the pseudonymous views attributed directly to himself
C. existential truth can be transmitted directly, like the result of a lecture
D. because existence-truth is a mode of existing and not a result, it is staged through pseudonyms who present existence-possibilities from within - and should be cited by name

Correct answer: D - because existence-truth is a mode of existing and not a result, it is staged through pseudonyms who present existence-possibilities from within - and should be cited by name

Explanation: Per the 'First and Last Declaration', the pseudonyms (Climacus, de Silentio, Haufniensis, Anti-Climacus) are existence-possibilities, not disguises; existential truth resists direct transfer, hence indirect communication.

MCQ 9

The slogan 'existence precedes essence' is properly attributed to:

A. Sartre - from the 1945 lecture Existentialism Is a Humanism; Heidegger repudiated it and Kierkegaard never used it
B. all three thinkers equally, as the shared existentialist creed
C. Heidegger, in Being and Time (1927)
D. Kierkegaard, in the Concluding Unscientific Postscript

Correct answer: A - Sartre - from the 1945 lecture Existentialism Is a Humanism; Heidegger repudiated it and Kierkegaard never used it

Explanation: It is Sartre's slogan (popular lecture, 1945/46). Heidegger explicitly rejected it in the Letter on Humanism; Kierkegaard never used it. Treat 'existentialism' as a family, not a school.

MCQ 10

Sartre's paper-knife analogy is meant to show that:

A. man has a fixed, God-given essence B. for an artefact essence (design/function) precedes existence, but with no divine artisan, for man existence precedes essence C. essence and existence are strictly identical D. consciousness is always consciousness of something

Correct answer: B - for an artefact essence (design/function) precedes existence, but with no divine artisan, for man existence precedes essence

Explanation: The artisan conceives the knife's essence before making it; classical theism made God such an artisan of man. Remove God and the order reverses for the human being.

MCQ 11

In the Letter on Humanism (1946/47), Heidegger's stance on Sartre's formula is that he:

A. endorsed 'existence precedes essence' as his own view B. simply ignored Sartre's existentialism C. rejected the formula as a metaphysical inversion that still remains within metaphysics D. claimed to have coined the formula before Sartre

Correct answer: C - rejected the formula as a metaphysical inversion that still remains within metaphysics

Explanation: Heidegger denies that his thought is existentialism and rejects 'existence precedes essence' as a mere inversion of the metaphysical essence/existence pair - still metaphysics.

MCQ 12

'The essence of Dasein lies in its existence' is best understood as meaning:

A. Dasein possesses a fixed human nature B. Dasein is a self-making project exactly like the Sartrean pour-soi C. Dasein's essence is simply its biological species-being D. Dasein's 'what' is its 'how' - its manner of Being - not a humanistic self-creation

Correct answer: D - Dasein's 'what' is its 'how' - its manner of Being - not a humanistic self-creation

Explanation: Heidegger's phrase concerns Dasein's way of Being (its existentiell possibilities), not a humanist doctrine of self-fashioning, which he repudiates.

MCQ 13

'Man is condemned to be free' means that:

A. we did not choose to exist, but once thrown we are inescapably self-defining - even non-choice is a choice B. freedom is a gift that may be politely declined C. freedom extends only to physically possible actions D. God condemns the sinner to the burden of freedom

Correct answer: A - we did not choose to exist, but once thrown we are inescapably self-defining - even non-choice is a choice

Explanation: Condemned, because we did not choose to exist; free, because thereafter we cannot escape choosing. The slogan is from Existentialism Is a Humanism (1945/46).

MCQ 14

Sartre's pivotal argument that no motive determines action is the claim that:

A. quantum indeterminacy breaks the causal chain B. a motive has force only through the meaning consciousness freely confers on it, so no motive operates prior to freedom C. an immaterial soul intervenes in the causal order D. the future is in principle unknowable

Correct answer: B - a motive has force only through the meaning consciousness freely confers on it, so no motive operates prior to freedom

Explanation: This is the meaning-conferral argument: since conferring meaning is itself an act of the pour-soi, determinism never reaches the free constituting of its own 'causes'.

MCQ 15

The three moods that, for Sartre, disclose our freedom are:

A. fear, guilt and boredom B. love, hate and indifference C. anguish (angoisse), abandonment (délaissement) and despair (désespoir) D. anxiety, nausea and shame

Correct answer: C - anguish (angoisse), abandonment (délaissement) and despair (désespoir)

Explanation: Anguish (before my freedom), abandonment (no God or a priori values) and despair (no guarantee the world will cooperate) follow from being condemned to be free.

MCQ 16

Sartre's Critique of Dialectical Reason (1960) is significant because it:

A. abandons the concept of freedom entirely for orthodox Marxism B. simply repeats Being and Nothingness without change C. offers a proof that determinism is true D. integrates scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert, conceding material constraint far more than before

Correct answer: D - integrates scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert, conceding material constraint far more than before

Explanation: The later work qualifies the early absolutism of radical freedom by showing how freedom can be conditioned (though not abolished) by material structures.

MCQ 17

Being-in-itself (en-soi) is characterised as:

A. full, self-identical, opaque being that 'is what it is', without consciousness B. nihilating consciousness that surpasses itself C. identical with the pour-soi D. pure nothingness with no positive being

Correct answer: A - full, self-identical, opaque being that 'is what it is', without consciousness

Explanation: The en-soi is massive positivity - solid, complete, non-relational (a stone simply is). It is contrasted with the nihilating pour-soi.

MCQ 18

Bad faith (mauvaise foi) is best defined as:

A. straightforwardly lying to other people B. a pre-reflective self-deception that identifies with facticity alone or transcendence alone in order to flee freedom C. honest and complete self-knowledge D. the operation of a Freudian unconscious

Correct answer: B - a pre-reflective self-deception that identifies with facticity alone or transcendence alone in order to flee freedom

Explanation: Bad faith is self-directed and pre-reflective; Sartre rejects the Freudian unconscious, grounding self-deception instead in the non-self-identity of consciousness.

MCQ 19

The over-scripted waiter exemplifies bad faith by:

A. denying that he has a body at all B. treating his customers as mere objects C. identifying with facticity alone - playing at 'being' a waiter by nature, forgetting he is free to quit D. identifying with transcendence alone and denying his role

Correct answer: C - identifying with facticity alone - playing at 'being' a waiter by nature, forgetting he is free to quit

Explanation: The waiter collapses transcendence into facticity, pretending his social role is a fixed nature - one of the two canonical forms of bad faith.

MCQ 20

'Man is a useless passion' expresses:

A. that human life has an objective, given meaning B. that consciousness is ultimately a thing (en-soi) C. that the en-soi strives to become the pour-soi D. the pour-soi's contradictory desire to become a self-identical yet self-aware pour-soi-en-soi (the God-ideal)

Correct answer: D - the pour-soi's contradictory desire to become a self-identical yet self-aware pour-soi-en-soi (the God-ideal)

Explanation: The pour-soi craves the solidity of the en-soi while keeping consciousness - an impossible synthesis (God), so the passion is 'useless'.

MCQ 21

For Sartre, the Look (le regard) primarily discloses:

A. being-for-others - under the Other's gaze I become an object, and shame is the proof B. the transcendental ego of pure consciousness C. the ready-to-hand character of equipment D. the leap of faith into the religious sphere

Correct answer: A - being-for-others - under the Other's gaze I become an object, and shame is the proof

Explanation: The Look opens the third ontological dimension, being-for-others; shame is the lived recognition that 'I am as the Other sees me', an object I did not choose to be.

MCQ 22

In the keyhole example, shame arises at the moment when:

A. I am still alone and wholly absorbed at the keyhole B. I hear footsteps and realise I am seen - I become the object the Other sees C. I reflectively examine my conscience D. I contemplate my own death

Correct answer: B - I hear footsteps and realise I am seen - I become the object the Other sees

Explanation: Absorbed at the keyhole there is no ego; the Other's approach turns surveying freedom into a seen object, and shame registers that objectification.

MCQ 23

For Sartre the basic structure of concrete relations with others is:

A. pre-established harmony B. an originally cooperative being-with (Mitsein) C. conflict - 'conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others' D. an ethical asymmetry in which the Other's face commands me

Correct answer: C - conflict - 'conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others'

Explanation: Because recognition fails whether I try to possess the Other's freedom (love, masochism) or reduce the Other to an object (sadism, hate), conflict is basic. Mitsein is Heidegger's, the face is Levinas's.

MCQ 24

'L'enfer, c'est les autres' (Huis clos, 1944) is best interpreted as:

A. the claim that relations with others are always literally hellish B. a proof that other people do not exist C. the view that solitude, not society, is hell D. the point that when relations are twisted the Other's judgment becomes the medium of self-torment - a reading Sartre himself corrected

Correct answer: D - the point that when relations are twisted the Other's judgment becomes the medium of self-torment - a reading Sartre himself corrected

Explanation: Sartre's own 1965 preface explains that the line describes distorted relations and characters who are dead (fixed) - not a blanket condemnation of others.

MCQ 25

'Being-in-the-world' (In-der-Welt-sein) is:

A. one unitary phenomenon that dissolves the subject/object split - not spatial containment B. a human being located inside a container-like world C. another name for the transcendental ego D. identical to Sartrean bad faith

Correct answer: A - one unitary phenomenon that dissolves the subject/object split - not spatial containment

Explanation: The hyphens are the doctrine: Dasein is never first a subject that later meets objects; describing it as a thing 'in' a world spatially forfeits the point.

MCQ 26

The relation between ready-to-hand (Zuhandenheit) and present-at-hand (Vorhandenheit) is that:

- A. the present-at-hand is primary and the ready-to-hand derived B. the ready-to-hand (equipment in use) is primary, and the present-at-hand object of theory appears when the tool breaks C. the two are equally primordial with no priority D. both are categories borrowed from Sartre

Correct answer: B - the ready-to-hand (equipment in use) is primary, and the present-at-hand object of theory appears when the tool breaks

Explanation: Absorbed practical coping is basic; the detached object with properties (theory's present-at-hand) shows up in breakdown - so theory presupposes practice.

MCQ 27

The 'existentialia' that structure Dasein's disclosedness are:

- A. sensation, perception and judgment B. the id, the ego and the superego C. Befindlichkeit (attunement), Verstehen (understanding/projection) and Rede (discourse) D. the aesthetic, the ethical and the religious

Correct answer: C - Befindlichkeit (attunement), Verstehen (understanding/projection) and Rede (discourse)

Explanation: Unlike 'categories' that apply to things, existentialia are structures of Dasein's Being; together they constitute its disclosedness (the 'there' of Da-sein).

MCQ 28

The formal structure of Care (Sorge) is:

- A. past, present and future as a line of 'nows' B. id, ego and superego C. aesthetic, ethical and religious D. 'ahead-of-itself - already-in (a world) - alongside (entities)'

Correct answer: D - 'ahead-of-itself - already-in (a world) - alongside (entities)'

Explanation: Care unifies projection (ahead-of-itself), thrownness (already-in) and absorption (alongside); its meaning is temporality.

MCQ 29

Heidegger's authenticity (Eigentlichkeit) is:

- A. an ontological modification of everydayness, not a moral virtue - and inauthenticity is not a moral failing B. simply being morally good C. being true to one's spontaneous feelings D. religious salvation of the soul

Correct answer: A - an ontological modification of everydayness, not a moral virtue - and inauthenticity is not a moral failing

Explanation: Authenticity and inauthenticity are modes of owning or not owning one's existence; Dasein is inauthentic 'proximally and for the most part', which is structural, not a vice.

MCQ 30

das Man ('the they') denotes:

- A. one specific evil individual B. the anonymous public self - the source of inauthenticity through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity C. the silent call of conscience D. the Kierkegaardian knight of faith

Correct answer: B - the anonymous public self - the source of inauthenticity through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity

Explanation: das Man is the impersonal 'one'/'they' that decides what one says and does; falling into it (Verfallen) is inauthenticity, and it is a structural feature of everydayness.

MCQ 31

Being-toward-death (Sein-zum-Tode) discloses death as:

- A. an external event simply to be feared B. a rational ground for contemplating suicide C. ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite - individualising Dasein, not the empirical event of dying D. a mere biological fact of no philosophical interest

Correct answer: C - ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite - individualising Dasein, not the empirical event of dying

Explanation: The four marks (ownmost, non-relational, certain, indefinite) show that being-toward-death is the disclosure of finitude, not morbid brooding or the empirical demise.

MCQ 32

The deepest objection to Heidegger's authenticity is that it is:

- A. too prescriptive about specific duties
- B. identical in content to Kierkegaard's faith
- C. a disguised form of hedonism
- D. formally empty - it says 'own your choices' without saying which, so it could dignify any resolute commitment

Correct answer: D - formally empty - it says 'own your choices' without saying which, so it could dignify any resolute commitment

Explanation: Because authenticity prescribes the how, not the what, critics (Adorno's 'jargon of authenticity'; Heidegger's own 1933) charge that it can validate any resolute stance.

MCQ 33

For Heidegger, temporality (Zeitlichkeit) is:

- A. the meaning of Care - three ecstases, not clock-time
- B. the infinite series of 'nows'
- C. merely a psychological sense of felt duration
- D. identical to Newtonian absolute time

Correct answer: A - the meaning of Care - three ecstases, not clock-time

Explanation: Temporality is the ontological meaning of Care; it is ecstatic (future/having-been/present), not the measurable now-series.

MCQ 34

Among the three ecstases, primacy belongs to:

- A. the present
- B. the future (Zukunft) - projection and being-toward-death, which temporalises the others; authenticity is futural
- C. having-been
- D. none; all three are strictly equal

Correct answer: B - the future (Zukunft) - projection and being-toward-death, which temporalises the others; authenticity is futural

Explanation: Past and present are temporalised out of the future: in running ahead to death Dasein gathers its thrown existence into a whole.

MCQ 35

'Vulgar' or ordinary time, for Heidegger, is:

- A. the primordial form of temporality
- B. identical with the three ecstases
- C. the infinite now-series - a derived, levelled-down form arising from falling
- D. a mode available only to authentic Dasein

Correct answer: C - the infinite now-series - a derived, levelled-down form arising from falling

Explanation: Clock-time (the endless sequence of nows) is a derivative flattening of ecstatic temporality, adopted by falling Dasein for public use.

MCQ 36

The three ecstases map onto the structure of Care as:

- A. future = alongside, present = ahead-of-itself, having-been = already-in
- B. they do not correspond to Care at all
- C. future = already-in, having-been = alongside, present = ahead-of-itself
- D. future = ahead-of-itself, having-been = already-in, present = alongside

Correct answer: D - future = ahead-of-itself, having-been = already-in, present = alongside

Explanation: Projection/future = ahead-of-itself; thrownness/having-been = already-in; making-present/present = alongside. The one-to-one correspondence is the structural key.

MCQ 37

The difference between fear and anxiety (dread/anguish) is that:

- A. fear has a definite object in the world, whereas anxiety has no definite object ('a nothing') and so discloses freedom and finitude
- B. anxiety is merely a more intense form of fear
- C. fear is objectless while anxiety has a definite object
- D. the two are, on analysis, identical

Correct answer: A - fear has a definite object in the world, whereas anxiety has no definite object ('a nothing') and so discloses freedom and finitude

Explanation: The distinction is structural, not one of degree: fear points at a thing and drives me into the world; anxiety, being objectless, individualises and discloses existence itself.

MCQ 38

'Anxiety is the dizziness of freedom' is found in:

A. Sartre's Being and Nothingness B. Kierkegaard's The Concept of Anxiety (1844), written under the pseudonym Vigilius Haufniensis C. Heidegger's Being and Time D. Hegel's Phenomenology of Spirit

Correct answer: B - Kierkegaard's The Concept of Anxiety (1844), written under the pseudonym Vigilius Haufniensis

Explanation: The image of the man growing dizzy at the abyss of possibility is Vigilius Haufniensis's (Kierkegaard), 1844; Angest is rendered 'dread' (Lowrie) or 'anxiety' (Hong).

MCQ 39

Sartre's canonical examples of anguish before one's own freedom are:

A. the waiter and the woman on the date B. Abraham and the knight of faith C. the cliff path (nothing prevents me from throwing myself over) and the gambler whose past resolve is powerless D. the paper-knife and the artisan

Correct answer: C - the cliff path (nothing prevents me from throwing myself over) and the gambler whose past resolve is powerless

Explanation: On the cliff I feel anguish not fear of the drop but before my freedom to jump; the gambler must remake yesterday's resolution now - both disclose freedom, not a worldly threat.

MCQ 40

The Danish word Kierkegaard uses, rendered 'dread' by Lowrie and 'anxiety' by Hong, is:

A. Angst B. angoisse C. Sorge D. Angest

Correct answer: D - Angest

Explanation: Angest is Kierkegaard's Danish term; Angst is Heidegger's German, angoisse is Sartre's French, and Sorge is Heidegger's 'Care' - a translation/provenance discipline point.

Remedial MCQ 41

Remedial - A frequent trap claims that 'existence precedes essence' is shared equally by all three thinkers. The correction is that:

A. it is Sartre's slogan; Heidegger disowned it (Letter on Humanism) and Kierkegaard never used it B. it is really Heidegger's slogan, adopted later by Sartre C. all three used it in exactly the same sense D. it originates with Kierkegaard in the Postscript

Correct answer: A - it is Sartre's slogan; Heidegger disowned it (Letter on Humanism) and Kierkegaard never used it

Explanation: Handle 'existentialism' as a family, not a school: only Sartre owns the slogan; Heidegger rejected it as metaphysical inversion, and the Christian Kierkegaard has no use for it.

Remedial MCQ 42

Remedial - A common misreading treats Kierkegaard's 'truth is subjectivity' as relativism. The correction is that:

A. it does entail that all truth is relative to the individual B. it concerns the mode of appropriation (passionate inwardness), not a denial of objective truth C. it denies objective truth even in mathematics and logic D. it means the crowd collectively decides what is true

Correct answer: B - it concerns the mode of appropriation (passionate inwardness), not a denial of objective truth

Explanation: Kierkegaard distinguishes the how from the what: objective truth stands for logic/science, but existential-religious truth requires inward appropriation. It is not relativism; 'the crowd is untruth'.

Remedial MCQ 43

Remedial - A trap equates Sartre's en-soi with 'matter' and the pour-soi with 'mind'. The correction is that:

A. the mind-matter equation is exactly right B. the en-soi is mind and the pour-soi is matter C. the distinction is ontological (self-identical being vs nihilating consciousness), not a mind-matter distinction D. both en-soi and pour-soi are kinds of consciousness

Correct answer: C - the distinction is ontological (self-identical being vs nihilating consciousness), not a mind-matter distinction

Explanation: En-soi is being that is what it is (self-identical); pour-soi is being that is not what it is (nihilating). Reading this as mind vs matter misses the ontological point.

Remedial MCQ 44

Remedial - A trap reads Heidegger's being-toward-death as fearing death or contemplating suicide. The correction is that:

A. it is indeed essentially about fearing death B. it is a study of the biology of dying C. it recommends suicide as an authentic act D. it discloses death as one's ownmost, non-relational possibility, individualising Dasein - not the empirical event

Correct answer: D - it discloses death as one's ownmost, non-relational possibility, individualising Dasein - not the empirical event

Explanation: Being-toward-death is the anticipatory disclosure of finitude that frees Dasein for authentic existence, not morbidity, biology or self-destruction.

Remedial MCQ 45

Remedial - A trap asserts that Sartre and Heidegger agree on freedom. The correction is that:

A. Sartre's freedom is absolute and subject-centred, while Heidegger's is ontological thrown-projection, not voluntarism B. they agree completely on radical, subject-centred freedom C. Heidegger's freedom is even more absolute than Sartre's D. neither thinker actually discusses freedom

Correct answer: A - Sartre's freedom is absolute and subject-centred, while Heidegger's is ontological thrown-projection, not voluntarism

Explanation: For Sartre consciousness IS freedom (absolute, subject-centred); Heidegger's freedom is Dasein's projection upon possibilities within thrownness - about Being's disclosure, not self-creation.

Remedial MCQ 46

Remedial - A trap treats Kierkegaard's stages as chronological phases one matures through. The correction is that:

A. they are indeed chronological life-phases B. they are qualitative spheres joined by the leap, and relapse is always possible C. they are Hegelian dialectical moments that sublate one another D. there are in fact five stages, not three

Correct answer: B - they are qualitative spheres joined by the leap, and relapse is always possible

Explanation: The aesthetic, ethical and religious are qualitative spheres; one does not grow out of a sphere by maturation but leaps, and can always relapse.

Remedial MCQ 47

Remedial - A trap presents 'leap of faith' as a literal Kierkegaardian term. The correction is that:

A. it is a precise translation of a single Kierkegaardian term B. Kierkegaard never discusses faith or leaping at all C. Kierkegaard writes of 'the leap' (Springet); the fused phrase 'leap of faith' is the English tradition's, not his own term D. the phrase originates with Sartre's lecture of 1945

Correct answer: C - Kierkegaard writes of 'the leap' (Springet); the fused phrase 'leap of faith' is the English tradition's, not his own term

Explanation: Provenance discipline: Kierkegaard speaks of the leap and of faith, but 'leap of faith' is a later English coinage - write 'the leap, what the English tradition calls the leap of faith'.

Remedial MCQ 48

Remedial - A trap attributes the epoche (bracketing) to Heidegger. The correction is that:

A. the epoche is Heidegger's own method B. the epoche is Sartre's method of nihilation C. the epoche is Kierkegaard's method of indirect communication D. the epoche is Husserl's method, which Heidegger rejects in favour of Dasein's being-in-the-world

Correct answer: D - the epoche is Husserl's method, which Heidegger rejects in favour of Dasein's being-in-the-world

Explanation: The epoche and phenomenological reduction are Husserl's; the 2018 Q4(a) question turns on Heidegger's rejection of that reduction - attribute the method correctly and keep the topics separate.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

EXAM APPLICATION 1 - Foundational Map - Three Thinkers, One Shared Conviction, Radical Differences

How the map frames every answer

- **Universal opener.** For any Existentialism PYQ one sentence orients the examiner: "Existentialism makes concrete existence prior to essence; its three classic thinkers - Kierkegaard (theistic), Sartre (atheistic) and Heidegger (ontological) - share that conviction but diverge on God, the self and authenticity." Then narrow to the exact demand. - **The three-thinker map is an answer tool, not decoration:** sketch the shared conviction and the three-way split, then place the asked concept on it, so the examiner sees you command the whole before diving into the part. - **Ownership facts that must be right:** this clause owns **14** Western Philosophy PYQ parts across 2018-2025 - joint-highest with Rationalism and Moore-Russell-Early Wittgenstein - with at least one part in every year. The 2018 'Epoche' question is owned here because its burden is Heidegger's rejection of reduction; Husserl's own Phenomenology parts are counted separately.

10-mark use: one orienting sentence, then straight to the demand. **15/20-mark use:** the map as a compact frame, the targeted thinker developed in depth, closing on how the part illuminates the shared conviction.

EXAM APPLICATION 2 - Kierkegaard - The Single Individual, Truth Is Subjectivity, the Three Stages, the Leap and Indirect Communication

Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic owns FOUR PYQs)

- **2020 Q3(a), 20m** - "Subjectivity is the truth" and the single individual. Spine: define subjectivity (mode of appropriation, not relativism) -> "subjectivity is untruth" complement -> the single individual against Hegel's System -> leap and passion -> verdict (fideism/elitism worries answered). - **2022 Q4(a), 20m** - subjectivity *and* the three stages. Spine: subjectivity as the *how* -> aesthetic/ethical/religious with their despairs (boredom/guilt/paradox) -> the leap between them -> against Hegel -> close on intensifying inwardness.
- **2023 Q1(d), 10m** - individual as the essence of spirit vs Hegel's universal spirit. Spine: Hegel absorbs the individual into Absolute Spirit; Kierkegaard makes spirit the individual's passionate self-relation - "the systematiser must still exist, choose and die." - **2024 Q1(e), 10m** - truth defined in terms of subjectivity. Spine: the *how* over the *what*; passionate inwardness; the God-example; *not* relativism; cite Climacus.
- **Directive care:** "critically discuss" demands a defended ruling - end on whether the leap is responsible fideism or an abdication of reason.

EXAM APPLICATION 3 - Existence and Essence - Sartre's Slogan, the Paper-Knife, and Heidegger's Rejection of Humanism

Verified route and answer architecture

- **2024 Q4(a), 20m (10+10)** is this subtopic's home question: "What do the existentialist thinkers mean by the slogan 'existence precedes essence'? How is human existence related to human freedom?" Two demands - unpack the slogan, then connect it to freedom. - **Part 1 spine:** paper-knife analogy -> no divine artisan (atheism as premise) -> existence first, essence self-made -> flag that it is *Sartre's* slogan: Heidegger repudiates it (Letter on Humanism), Kierkegaard never uses it. Handle "existentialism" as a family, not a school.
- **Part 2 spine:** with no fixed essence, man is radically free - "condemned to be free," inescapable, accompanied by anguish; responsibility follows because in choosing I choose an image of man; Heidegger's freedom is projection upon possibilities, not voluntarism; Kierkegaard's freedom is real but bounded by the God-relation. - **Close:** the primacy of existence empowers an ethics of responsibility, but critics ask whether ungrounded freedom can

generate values without collapsing into decisionism.

EXAM APPLICATION 4 - Sartre I - Radical Freedom, Choice, Responsibility, and the Moods of Anguish, Abandonment and Despair

Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic owns THREE PYQs)

- **2019 Q4(c), 15m** - freedom of choice and determinism. Spine: Sartre denies causal, psychological and social determinism -> the meaning-conferral argument (a motive is a motive only through conferred sense) -> "no excuses" -> freedom within situation -> Marxist objection and the *Critique's* concession -> verdict: determinism is a *false* problem that treats the *pour-soi* as a thing.
- **2020 Q4(a), 20m** - "You can always make something out of what you have been made into." Spine: facticity ("what you have been made into") vs transcendence ("make something out of") -> the *pour-soi* as project -> condemned to be free, total responsibility -> the Marxist limit and Sartre's later concession -> verdict on situated freedom.
- **2021 Q4(b), 15m** - "If I do not choose, I am still choosing." Spine: freedom is inescapable, non-choice is choice (usually bad faith) -> responsibility and "no excuses" -> "in choosing myself I choose man" -> is the distinction between choosing-not-to-choose and being unable to choose real? -> verdict: dramatises the inescapability of freedom. - **Directive care:** "critically discuss" needs a first-line ruling on radical freedom before exposition.

EXAM APPLICATION 5 - Sartre II - Bad Faith, Facticity/Transcendence, and the Pour-soi / En-soi Ontology

Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic owns TWO PYQs)

- **2023 Q3(c), 15m** - "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is." Spine: the formula captures the *pour-soi's* non-self-identity against the *en-soi* -> "is what it is not" (ahead of itself, defined by a future that does not yet exist) -> "is not what it is" (cannot coincide with its facticity/past; the waiter transcends the role) -> how: nihilation (*neantisation*) -> consequences: freedom, bad faith, temporality, the "useless passion" -> verdict.
- **2025 Q1(c), 10m** - difference between being-for-itself and being-in-itself. Spine: *en-soi* = full, self-identical, opaque, no consciousness; *pour-soi* = nihilating, self-surpassing, constituted by freedom; the two formulas -> close on the *pour-soi's* impossible desire to become *en-soi* (the God-ideal), "man is a useless passion."
- **Bad faith feeds 2018 Q1(d):** inauthenticity and bad faith lead to alienation - name the waiter and the woman on the date, and the facticity/transcendence structure, then the objectifying look (subtopic 6). - **Directive care:** "bring out the chief features" wants the technical machinery (nihilation, non-self-identity), not a life-lesson about honesty.

EXAM APPLICATION 6 - Sartre III - The Look (le regard), Being-for-Others, Shame, and the Conflict of Recognition

Verified route and answer architecture

- **2018 Q1(d), 10m** is where the Look earns its keep: inauthenticity + bad faith -> **alienation**. Spine: bad faith (facticity-only/transcendence-only) makes consciousness deny its unstable freedom (inauthenticity) -> living through fixed social roles or the objectifying **Look** alienates the self, which now lives as the object the Other sees -> name the waiter and the keyhole -> objection (radical freedom ignores circumstance) and Sartre's situated-freedom reply. - **Universal enrichment:** any full Sartre answer (freedom, bad faith, the self) should reserve one sentence for being-for-others - an answer that gives only in-itself/for-itself omits a third of the book, including the body, shame, love and conflict. - **20-mark move:** deploy the four-account comparison (Husserl / Heidegger / Sartre / Levinas) and the corrected "hell is other people" to close with authority.

EXAM APPLICATION 7 - Heidegger I - Dasein and Being-in-the-World: Worldhood, Equipment, the Existentialia and Care

Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic anchors TWO PYQs)

- **2018 Q4(a), 20m** - "What is 'Epoche'? How does Heidegger reject this method of phenomenological reduction? Explain being-in-the-world as opposed to the transcendental ego." Spine: define *Epoche* correctly as *Husserl's* device (bracketing the natural attitude's existence-posit to reach the transcendental ego) -> Heidegger's rejection: the more primordial condition is Dasein's already-involved being-in-the-world; subject and object are *derivative* abstractions from practical involvement -> equipment, ready-to-hand vs present-at-hand, the broken hammer -> being-in-the-world as unitary, dissolving the transcendental ego -> verdict. Keep *Epoche* attributed to Husserl; do

not import Sartrean bad faith.

- **2022 Q2(a), 20m** - critical account of being-in-the-world + authenticity (authenticity developed in subtopic 8). Spine: being-in-the-world as the *what* (unitary, worldhood, existentialia, Care) -> authenticity as a modification *within* it, not an escape -> criticisms (formal emptiness, Levinas) -> close: being-in-the-world is the *what*, authenticity the *how*.
- **Directive care:** "critical account" needs a defended ruling - can one step outside being-in-the-world at all (the very move the Husserlian reduction attempts)?

EXAM APPLICATION 8 - Heidegger II - Authenticity and Inauthenticity: das Man, Falling, the Call of Conscience and Being-toward-Death

Verified routes and answer architecture (this subtopic anchors TWO PYQs)

- **2019 Q3(a), 20m** - "Is Dasein authentic existence for Heidegger?" The trap is in the question: Dasein is *not* defined as authentic existence - authenticity is one *modification*; Dasein is mostly inauthentic (das Man, falling), and that is structural. Spine: Dasein's being = Care -> authenticity = owning it through anticipatory resoluteness (being-toward-death + call of conscience) -> then temporality (subtopic 9) -> verdict. (Temporality is the second half of this question.)
- **2022 Q2(a), 20m** - being-in-the-world (subtopic 7) + "the problem of authenticity." Spine: being-in-the-world as unitary -> *das Man*, falling, inauthenticity as default -> call of conscience + being-toward-death -> authenticity as a *formal* modification (owning thrown projection), not a moral category -> criticisms (formal emptiness, Levinas, the political danger) -> close: being-in-the-world is the *what*, authenticity the *how*.
- **Directive care:** "critically examine authenticity" makes assessment dominant, and the *non-moral* reading is the point to defend.

EXAM APPLICATION 9 - Heidegger III - Temporality (Zeitlichkeit): the Three Ecstases, Future-Priority, and Primordial versus Vulgar Time

Verified route and answer architecture

- **2019 Q3(a), 20m** - the second, decisive half: "How does he relate temporality with Dasein?" Spine: Dasein's being = Care -> the *meaning* of Care is temporality -> three ecstases (future/having-been/present) with future-priority -> anticipatory resoluteness gathers Dasein into a whole and grounds authentic historicity -> primordial vs vulgar time (the now-series is derived) -> criticism (Division III unpublished; Sartre; Levinas) -> verdict: Dasein is the temporal entity that *can* be authentic, not "authentic existence" by definition.
- **15/20-mark move:** map each ecstasis to its Care element (ahead-of-itself / already-in / alongside) - the one-to-one correspondence is the examiner-strong structural point. - **Directive care:** relate temporality *to authenticity* - the future-priority is what links the two analyses; do not treat temporality as a separate topic.

EXAM APPLICATION 10 - Comparison and Answer Spine - Fear versus Angst across the Three Thinkers, and the Cross-Thinker Synthesis

Verified routes and answer architecture

- **No single owner PYQ, high cross-question value.** The fear/anxiety distinction and the cross-thinker comparisons are the closing paragraphs that turn a competent answer into a distinguished one on *any* Existentialism question - existence/essence, freedom, authenticity, subjectivity, being-in-the-world.
- **Whenever a question names a mood:** give the structural difference (object vs no-object), the disclosive payoff, and one canonical example from each thinker - never call anxiety "a stronger kind of fear." - **Answer spine for every Existentialism question:**
 1. one orienting sentence (shared primacy of existence + the three-way split);
 2. exact demand, decoded by the directive word;
 3. named source / example (paper-knife, keyhole, broken hammer, Abraham, the gambler);
 4. objection and reply (Marxist, Levinas, naturalist, Hegelian);
 5. a defended verdict, using the graded verdict bank.

- **Directive care:** "bring out the difference between fear and dread" wants a *structural* difference in the object plus the disclosive payoff, not a scale of intensity.

Workbook Source Audit

- Exact PYQ wording, year and marks: local Western Philosophy Paper I bank, 2018-2025.
- Exactly 14 owner questions, at least one in every year 2018-2025 (joint-highest owner in the paper).
- Ownership discipline: the 2018 Q4(a) part uses 'Epoche', which is Husserl's method of phenomenological reduction - attributed to Husserl and kept separate from the Phenomenology topic; Existentialism owns the part because its burden is Heidegger's being-in-the-world. Concepts are attributed precisely among Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger.
- Model solutions authored at examiner grade: thesis -> named source / argument -> analysis -> objection/reply -> verdict, each closing with a "Why this earns marks" note.
- MCQs: 40 core plus 8 remedial, exactly 48, strict A-B-C-D rotation twelve times.
- Original Mains: one solved 10-marker, one solved 15-marker and one solved 20-marker.
- Provenance discipline observed throughout (Springet vs "leap of faith"; slogans from Existentialism Is a Humanism 1945/46, not Being and Nothingness 1943; Being and Time 1927 unfinished; Angest = dread/anxiety).
- No current-affairs anchor is used (no verified development found 2026-02-19 to 2026-08-19); relevance is static and syllabus-driven.
- Final consolidated register notes are intentionally excluded from this workbook.

Practice Design

The workbook sequence is the fourteen exact verified PYQs -> 40 core MCQs -> 8 remedial MCQs -> original 10/15/20-mark Mains practice. There are no register notes and no canonical apparatus block in this workbook.

DIRECTIVE -> THESIS -> DOCTRINE -> NAMED SOURCE / EXAMPLE -> OBJECTION / REPLY -> VERDICT

SOLVED PYQ BANK - EXACTLY 14 VERIFIED OWNER QUESTIONS

Exact wording, year and marks are parsed from the continuous local Western Philosophy Paper I bank for 2018-2025. Existentialism owns exactly 14 primary parts, at least one in every year 2018-2025 (joint-highest owner in the paper). Ownership discipline: the 2018 Q4(a) part uses 'Epoche', which is Husserl's method - it is attributed to Husserl and the Phenomenology material is kept separate; the burden of the question is Heidegger's being-in-the-world, so Existentialism owns it.

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: How does Sartre connect inauthenticity with bad faith? Why does Sartre show that inauthenticity and bad faith lead to alienation? Discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. For Sartre inauthenticity *is* the settled practice of bad faith, and bad faith produces alienation because it makes consciousness live as the object it pretends to be - so the three terms name one downward movement, not three separate facts.

Doctrine and evidence. Every human reality has two dimensions: **facticity** (*facticity* - body, past, role, situation) and **transcendence** (freedom to surpass the given). **Bad faith** (*mauvaise foi*) is the project of collapsing the two - identifying with facticity *alone* (the waiter who so perfectly "is" a waiter that he forgets he is free to quit) or with transcendence *alone* (the woman on the date who treats her captured hand as a mere thing). This is possible because the *pour-soi* "is what it is not and is not what it is": consciousness is non-self-identical, so it can hold a truth and its denial in one pre-reflective stance, with no Freudian unconscious required. **Inauthenticity** is bad faith made habitual: consciousness chronically denies its own unstable freedom.

Analysis - how alienation follows. Alienation is the terminus. Living through fixed social roles or, above all, under the objectifying **Look** (*le regard*), the self comes to exist *as the object the Other sees* - it acquires "an outside" it did not choose and cannot control. In fleeing the anguish of freedom into role and role-into-thing, consciousness estranges itself from its own transcendence: it is present to itself as an alien object. Thus inauthenticity (the stance) -> bad faith (its mechanism) -> alienation (its result).

Objection and reply. Critics (the Marxist tradition, Merleau-Ponty) object that this psychologises alienation and ignores the *structural* oppression that genuinely limits people. Sartre's reply is situated freedom - one always chooses *from* a factual situation, never from nowhere - and his later *Critique of Dialectical Reason* (1960) concedes scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert far more than *Being and Nothingness* (1943) did.

Verdict. Bad faith is Sartre's most successful concept because it explains self-deception without splitting the self; its limit is normative - if all consciousness is non-self-identical, what finally distinguishes bad faith from ordinary living? The promised ethics of authenticity was gestured at in a footnote and never written.

Why this earns marks: it fuses the three demanded terms into one causal chain, names the canonical examples (waiter, woman on the date) and the Look, deploys the ontological formula that makes bad faith possible, and closes with a graded verdict plus the correct provenance of the later self-revision.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: What is 'Epoché'? How does Heidegger reject this method of phenomenological reduction? Explain Heidegger's concept of 'being in the world' as opposed to the concept of a transcendental ego.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. *Epoche* is **Husserl's** device, not Heidegger's; Heidegger rejects it because the reduction presupposes exactly what is most questionable - a worldless spectator-subject - whereas the primordial fact is Dasein's always-already **being-in-the-world**. (Ownership note: this part belongs to Existentialism because its burden is Heidegger's alternative; *Epoche* itself is attributed to Husserl and kept separate from the Phenomenology topic.)

What Epoche is (attributed correctly). In Husserl the **epoche** (bracketing, *Einklammerung*) suspends the "general thesis" of the natural attitude - the standing posit that the world exists independently - so that consciousness can be described purely as it gives itself. The **phenomenological reduction** then leads back (*re-ducere*) to the **transcendental ego**, the constituting field *for which* the world has sense. Husserl's is thus a philosophy that begins by *withholding the world*.

Heidegger's rejection. Heidegger's objection is that this starting point is already an abstraction. To bracket the world and retreat to a transcendental ego is to assume that consciousness *could* be world-less - the very Cartesian picture (subject inside, world outside) that must be overcome. The more primordial condition is that Dasein is *always already* absorbed, concerned, involved: subject and object are *derivative* precipitates of practical involvement, not the bedrock. One cannot "bracket" the world because one is never outside it.

Being-in-the-world vs the transcendental ego. "Being-in-the-world" (*In-der-Welt-sein*) is **one unitary phenomenon** - the hyphens are the doctrine; it resists decomposition into subject + relation + object. Its evidence is the analysis of **equipment**: a hammer is first met as **ready-to-hand** (*Zuhandenheit*), absorbed in an "in-order-to" web (nail-board-house-dwelling), the *worldhood* of the world. Only when it **breaks** does the bare **present-at-hand** (*Vorhandenheit*) object of theoretical staring appear - so the detached ego of theory is a *founded*, deficient mode, not the origin. Against Husserl's constituting ego stands Dasein's thrown, practical disclosedness (*Befindlichkeit*, *Verstehen*, *Rede*), unified as **Care** (*Sorge*).

Objection, reply, verdict. Husserlians reply that Heidegger has merely relocated, not answered, the constitution question, and that description still needs *some* methodological purification. But the decisive point stands: if the subject is always already worldly, the reduction cannot reach a presuppositionless residue. Provenance discipline: cite *Being and Time* (1927) by section (worldhood ss.15-18, Care s.41); the work is **unfinished** - never say it "completes" the analysis of Being.

Why this earns marks: it fixes ownership (*Epoche* = Husserl), states the reduction accurately before criticising it, runs the marked being-in-the-world sequence (refuse the split -> *Zuhandenheit/Vorhandenheit* -> broken hammer ->

Care), and observes provenance discipline on the unfinished text.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q3(a), 20 marks

Question: Is Dasein authentic existence for Heidegger? How does he relate temporality with Dasein? Discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. No - Dasein is **not** by definition "authentic existence." Authenticity is one *modification* of Dasein's being; Dasein is inauthentic "proximally and for the most part," and Heidegger relates temporality to Dasein by showing that **temporality is the meaning of Care**, the very structure that makes both modes possible.

Correcting the question. The trap is in the wording. Dasein (being-there) is the entity whose own Being is an issue for it; its being is **Care** (*Sorge*): "ahead-of-itself - already-in (a world) - alongside (entities)." Falling into **das Man** (the anonymous "they"), through idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity, is *inauthenticity*, and it is a **structural** feature, not a deficiency or moral failing. Authenticity (*Eigentlichkeit*) is the owning of Care through the **call of conscience** and **being-toward-death** (*Sein-zum-Tode*) - death disclosed as ownmost, non-relational, certain and indefinite - issuing in **anticipatory resoluteness** (*vorlaufende Entschlossenheit*).

Temporality related to Dasein. The decisive second half: the *meaning* of Care is **temporality** (*Zeitlichkeit*). Dasein exists as three **ecstases** (ek-stasis, "standing out"): the **future** (*Zukunft* - coming toward oneself, projection, being-toward-death), **having-been** (*Gewesenheit* - thrownness, facticity), and the **present** (*Gegenwart* - making-present). These map one-to-one onto Care (ahead-of-itself / already-in / alongside). The **future has primacy**: in running ahead to death Dasein gathers its thrown existence into a **whole** and grounds authentic **historicity**. Ordinary clock-time - the infinite "now-series" - is a *derived, levelled-down* (**vulgar**) form; primordial temporality is ecstatic and finite.

Objection and reply. *Being and Time* (1927) is **unfinished** - Division III ("Time and Being") was never published - so the promised move from Dasein's temporality to the meaning of Being as such is not delivered; Heidegger later underwent the "turn" (*Kehre*). Sartre objects that temporality should ground *freedom*, not merely formal ontology; Levinas, that being-toward-death individualises excessively, neglecting the Other's time.

Verdict. Dasein is not "authentic existence" but the entity whose being (Care) is **temporal** and which *can* exist authentically by owning its finitude. Authenticity is the futural gathering of a temporal being, not its definition.

Why this earns marks: it refuses the false premise in the first line, maps the three ecstases onto Care, foregrounds future-primacy as the link between temporality and authenticity, and disciplines the provenance of the unfinished project.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q4(c), 15 marks

Question: How does Sartre look at the problem of freedom of choice and determinism? Explain.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. Sartre treats "freedom versus determinism" as a **false problem**: determinism misunderstands the *pour-soi* by treating it as an *en-soi*, a thing among causes, whereas consciousness is nihilating freedom, so no motive can determine it in advance.

Doctrine and the pivotal argument. The *pour-soi* is constituted by **nihilation** (*neantisation*) and transcendence: it stands back from any given, questions it, imagines otherwise, and projects beyond it. The pivot is **meaning-conferral**: a desire, emotion or circumstance becomes a *motive* only through the meaning consciousness freely confers on it - and conferring meaning is itself an act of freedom. Therefore no motive operates *prior to* freedom; determinism's causal chain never reaches the choosing that constitutes its own "causes." Hence "there are no excuses" - I do not *suffer* my passion, I choose to surrender to it; I do not *undergo* my situation, I choose its sense.

Freedom within situation. This is not the fantasy that I can do anything. Sartre grants **facticity** ("situation") and insists freedom operates *within* it, not *despite* it: I cannot fly, but I remain free to interpret my inability and to project

against it. Freedom is absolute in the *field of meaning*, not in the field of physical possibility. (The slogans "condemned to be free," "man is nothing but what he makes of himself" come from the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946, not from *Being and Nothingness* of 1943 - a precision worth signalling.)

Objection and reply. The strongest objection is psychological and social: extreme coercion, mental illness and structural oppression seem to limit not only action but the very *awareness* of alternatives (Merleau-Ponty, the Marxist critique). Sartre's reply is situated freedom, and his later **Critique of Dialectical Reason** (1960) integrates scarcity, seriality and the "practico-inert," conceding material constraint far more than before - a significant self-revision, not a refutation.

Verdict. The radical thesis is unfalsifiable as stated, and Sartre came to qualify it; the defensible residue is not "we are absolutely free" but "no situation's meaning is settled independently of an act of freedom" - which is enough to defeat determinism without absurdity.

Why this earns marks: it names the false-problem diagnosis, supplies the meaning-conferral argument (the examiner-critical step), distinguishes freedom-of-meaning from freedom-of-action, and closes with the graded verdict plus accurate provenance of the later concession.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q3(a), 20 marks

Question: What does Kierkegaard mean by saying "Subjectivity is the truth" in the context of the problem of 'the single individual'?

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

Model solution

Thesis. By "Subjectivity is the truth" Kierkegaard does **not** mean that truth is whatever the individual feels; he means that for existential and religious truth the decisive thing is the *how* - the mode of appropriation - and that this truth can be lived only by "the single individual" (*den Enkelte*), never by the anonymous crowd or the Hegelian System.

Doctrine and evidence. The claim comes from the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), written under the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus** - cite the pseudonym, as Kierkegaard's own "First and Last Declaration" asks. Its target is Hegel's objective System, which dissolves the existing person into a moment of the universal. Kierkegaard distinguishes the *what* (objective content) from the *how* (the manner of holding it): for logic and mathematics objective truth suffices, but for the truths one must *exist* - ethical and religious truth - "an objective uncertainty held fast in the most passionate inwardness is the truth, the highest truth attainable for an existing individual." Truth here is a matter of infinite personal commitment and risk, not of detached demonstration.

The single individual. The correlate of subjectivity is *den Enkelte*. "The crowd is untruth" - not because groups are always wrong, but because the crowd enables ethical evasion; responsibility can be borne only by one who stands alone (before God or before the ethical demand). The System can contain everything except the one who builds it: "a logical system is possible; an existential system is impossible."

Guarding against relativism (the marked point). The standard misreading is that "truth is subjectivity" collapses into relativism. The reply: the doctrine concerns the *mode of appropriation*, not the propositional content; Kierkegaard does not deny objective truth in logic or science, he denies its *sufficiency* for existence. Complementing it, he can even say "subjectivity is *untruth*" - before God the individual, in sin, is in untruth and needs the paradox of faith - which shows the doctrine is not a celebration of arbitrary feeling.

Objection, reply, verdict. Hegelians charge fideism and elitism (who can achieve such inwardness?). Kierkegaard answers that reason is not *wrong* but *limited* - it cannot deliver what the existing individual needs. Verdict: "truth is subjectivity" is a permanent critique of impersonal system-philosophy, defensible precisely because it is a claim about *how* one must hold existential truth, not a denial that anything is objectively so.

Why this earns marks: it decodes the *how/what* distinction, ties subjectivity to *den Enkelte* and "the crowd is untruth," pre-empts the relativist misreading with the complementary "subjectivity is untruth," attributes the text to Climacus, and delivers a judged conclusion.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: "You can always make something out of what you have been made into." Critically discuss this statement by Sartre with reference to his views on existentialism.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. "You can always make something out of what you have been made into" compresses Sartre's whole doctrine of **situated freedom**: "what you have been made into" is **facticity**, "make something out of" is **transcendence**, and the sentence asserts that facticity is always raw material for a free project, never a destiny.

Doctrine and evidence. The *pour-soi* is not a thing with a fixed nature but a **project** - it exists by surpassing the given toward chosen ends. Facticity (*facticity*) - body, class, past, the way others have shaped me - is real and inescapable; but it has no fixed *meaning* until freedom confers one. Because I am "**condemned to be free**" (the phrase is from the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946, not from *Being and Nothingness* of 1943), I cannot *not* choose what to make of what has been made of me - even passivity is a choice, usually **bad faith**. Total **responsibility** follows: "there are no excuses," because circumstance supplies the material, never the verdict.

Analysis - the meaning-conferral core. The engine of the claim is that a condition constrains me only through the sense I give it: the same working-class origin can be lived as humiliation, as spur, or as solidarity. So even oppression does not *determine* the response; it sets the situation within which a free response is fashioned. This is why Sartre can say freedom is absolute in the field of meaning while granting that it is not unlimited in the field of action.

Objection and reply (critically discuss). The Marxist objection (Merleau-Ponty) is that this ignores how structural oppression cripples not just action but the *awareness* of alternatives - that "you can always make something" is false for those ground down by scarcity. Sartre's own **Critique of Dialectical Reason** (1960) is the honest response: it integrates scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert, conceding that freedom can be deeply *conditioned* without being abolished. The statement therefore marks the *early* Sartre; the mature Sartre qualifies its optimism.

Verdict. Read as "no situation's meaning is settled independently of an act of freedom," the sentence is defensible and defeats determinism; read as "circumstances never really limit us," it is the overstatement Sartre himself outgrew. The graded position keeps the former and drops the latter.

Why this earns marks: it maps the quotation onto facticity/transcendence, supplies the meaning-conferral mechanism, presses and answers the Marxist objection with the correct later text, and rules with a graded verdict rather than endorsing the slogan flatly.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q4(b), 15 marks

Question: "I can always choose, but I ought to know that if I do not choose, I am still choosing". Critically discuss Sartre's conception of choice and responsibility in the light of above statement.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. "I can always choose, but... if I do not choose, I am still choosing" dramatises Sartre's claim that **freedom is inescapable**: because the *pour-soi*'s very being is freedom, non-choice is itself a choice - usually a choice in **bad faith** to let others or circumstances decide - and total responsibility follows.

Doctrine and evidence. The *pour-soi* is nihilating consciousness; it cannot coincide with itself and cannot suspend its freedom, because freedom is *what it is*, not a property it has. Hence there is no neutral ground "outside" choosing: to defer, to conform, to "wait and see" is to choose to let the situation or the Other decide - a flight from the anguish of freedom, i.e. bad faith (pretending I am not free). This is why "man is **condemned to be free**" - condemned, because he did not choose to exist; free, because once thrown he is inescapably self-defining.

Analysis - choice and responsibility. Since every state I am in is *freely sustained*, I bear **total responsibility**: "there are no excuses." Responsibility widens further - "**in choosing myself I choose man**": every choice posits an image of what a human being ought to be, a quasi-Kantian universalisation that is the source of **anguish's** weight. Choice is thus never merely private; it legislates.

Objection and reply (critically discuss). The sharpest objection questions the very distinction the statement rests on: is "choosing not to choose" really different from *being unable* to choose? Structural oppression - poverty, coercion, indoctrination - seems to limit not only action but the awareness of alternatives, so that "you are still choosing" can sound like blaming the victim. Sartre's reply is situated freedom, and his later **Critique of Dialectical Reason** (1960) concedes scarcity, seriality and the practico-inert - a real qualification of the doctrine's early absolutism.

Verdict. The statement is true as an account of the *inescapability* of freedom - there is no exit from choosing for a being whose existence is freedom - but its moral use must be tempered by the recognition that situations condition how, and how freely, one chooses. "Condemned to be free" is an ontological structure, not a licence to ignore circumstance.

Why this earns marks: it decodes the quotation via inescapable freedom and bad-faith non-choice, links choice to responsibility and universalisation, presses the strongest objection and gives Sartre's later concession, and closes with a defended, graded ruling.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2022 Q2(a), 20 marks

Question: Provide a critical account of Heidegger's Being-in-the-world and discuss the problem of 'authenticity' in the context of Dasein.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. Being-in-the-world is the fundamental constitution of Dasein, and authenticity is a **modification within** that structure, never an escape from it: being-in-the-world is the *what* of Dasein, authenticity the *how*.

Critical account of being-in-the-world. "Being-in-the-world" (*In-der-Welt-sein*) is **one unitary phenomenon** whose hyphens dissolve the Cartesian subject/object split - describing Dasein as "a human being located in the world" forfeits the doctrine. Its evidence is **worldhood**: entities are first met as **ready-to-hand** equipment (*Zuhandenheit*) inside an "in-order-to" referential totality (hammer-nail-house-dwelling); the detached **present-at-hand** object (*Vorhandenheit*) of theory appears only when equipment **breaks**, so theoretical cognition is a *founded*, deficient mode. Dasein's disclosedness is structured by the **existentialia** - *Befindlichkeit* (attunement/mood), *Verstehen* (understanding as projection), *Rede* (discourse) - unified as **Care** (*Sorge*): "ahead-of-itself - already-in - alongside."

The problem of authenticity. Dasein first exists as **das Man** (the anonymous "they"), dispersed in idle talk, curiosity and ambiguity - **falling** (*Verfallen*), which is *structural*, not a moral fault. **Authenticity** (*Eigentlichkeit*) is reached through the silent **call of conscience** and **being-toward-death** (*Sein-zum-Tode*) - death as ownmost, non-relational, certain, indefinite - issuing in **anticipatory resoluteness**. The marked point: authenticity is **not a moral category**; it is a *formal* modification of everydayness, owning one's thrown projection. It does not take Dasein *out* of the world; it lets Dasein be in-the-world in a way that is *owned* rather than dispersed.

Objection and reply. The decisive criticism is that authenticity is **formally empty**: prescribing no content - "own your choices," not *which* choices - it could dignify any resolute commitment ("a Nazi could be authentic"). Adorno's "jargon of authenticity" and Heidegger's own 1933 complicity press this; Levinas answers with the primacy of the Other over death, Arendt with natality over mortality. Heidegger's defence - fundamental ontology is not ethics - is textually correct but philosophically unsatisfying. Provenance: *Being and Time* (1927) is unfinished; cite by section.

Verdict. Being-in-the-world is Heidegger's decisive dissolution of Cartesian dualism; authenticity is its most contestable extension, powerful as ontology and hazardous as ethics precisely because of its deliberate formality.

Why this earns marks: it treats the hyphens as the doctrine, runs the equipment/broken-hammer analysis, insists on the non-moral reading of authenticity, and lands the formal-emptiness objection with named critics and correct provenance.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: How does Soren Kierkegaard define the notion of 'subjectivity'? Explain it with reference to three stages of existence as propounded by him.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. For Kierkegaard "subjectivity" is not private feeling but **passionate inwardness** - the mode in which an existing individual appropriates existential truth - and the **three stages of existence** (aesthetic, ethical, religious) trace the intensification of that inwardness, joined not by logical transition but by the **leap**.

Subjectivity defined. Against Hegel's objective System, Kierkegaard (through the pseudonym **Johannes Climacus**, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846) holds that for the truths one must *exist* the decisive factor is the *how*, not the *what*: "truth is subjectivity" means truth as infinite passionate inwardness, commitment and risk, not detached demonstration. It is **not relativism** - it concerns the mode of appropriation, not a denial of objective (logical, scientific) truth. Its correlate is *den Enkelte*, the single individual; "the crowd is untruth."

The three stages. (1) **Aesthetic** - life for enjoyment, immediacy, possibility and irony (the seducer of *Either/Or*, 1843); it dissolves into boredom and **despair**. (2) **Ethical** - the self commits to universal duty, marriage, vocation (Judge William); it discloses guilt, for the earnest self cannot fulfil the moral law. (3) **Religious** - faith before God, the paradox, the absurd; **Abraham** (*Fear and Trembling*, 1843, by **Johannes de Silentio**) is the **knight of faith** who by "**infinite resignation**" and the "**double movement**" performs the **teleological suspension of the ethical** - faith overriding the universal moral law. These are **qualitative spheres**, not chronological phases; one does not mature out of the aesthetic, one **leaps**, and relapse is always possible.

The leap and the link to subjectivity. The movement between spheres is decisional, not dialectical - "the leap" (Kierkegaard writes of *Springet*; the fused phrase "**leap of faith**" is the English tradition's, not his term). Subjectivity *is* this intensification: from dispersion (aesthetic) through duty (ethical) to "the absolute relation to the Absolute" (religious).

Objection, reply, verdict. Hegelians charge fideism and elitism; Kierkegaard replies that reason is limited, not refuted, and that responsibility requires standing alone. Verdict: the doctrine is a permanent critique of impersonal system-philosophy - subjectivity as the deepening of inwardness across three incommensurable spheres, held together only by the leap.

Why this earns marks: it defines subjectivity as the *how*, sets out the three stages as qualitative spheres with their canonical figures, attributes texts to the correct pseudonyms, disciplines the "leap of faith" provenance, and guards against the relativist misreading.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2023 Q1(d), 10 marks

Question: How does Kierkegaard argue against Hegel's idea of universal spirit in favour of the individual as the essence of spirit? Critically discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. Kierkegaard argues against Hegel's "universal spirit" by insisting that spirit is realised only as the **self-relation of the existing single individual** (*den Enkelte*), which the System can never absorb: the individual is the essence of spirit precisely because he cannot be *sublated* into the universal.

Doctrine and evidence. For Hegel, *Geist* comes to itself as **Absolute Spirit**, and the individual is a vanishing moment in a dialectical whole that reconciles all oppositions. Kierkegaard's counter, pressed through the pseudonyms (notably **Climacus**, *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, 1846), is structural, not a list of complaints: "a **logical** system is possible; an **existential** system is impossible" - the System can contain everything except the one who builds it, the existing thinker who must still choose, suffer and die. Spirit is not an impersonal cosmic process but the individual's **self-relation** - "the self is a relation that relates itself to itself" (*Anti-Climacus*, *The Sickness unto Death*, 1849).

Analysis - the shape of the opposition. Against Hegel's **both/and** (mediation) Kierkegaard sets **either/or** (decision); against sublation, the **leap**; against the lecture, **indirect communication**. Where Hegel resolves the "Unhappy Consciousness" into a higher unity, Kierkegaard holds that the existing individual's tension with the universal is *irreducible* - it is lived, not thought away. "The crowd is untruth": to be dissolved into the universal (System, public, objective Christianity) is ethical evasion; genuine spirit requires standing alone, ultimately before God.

Objection and reply. Hegelians charge that elevating the singular individual over the community undermines ethics and social responsibility, and courts fideism. Kierkegaard replies that only the individual who stands alone can bear responsibility at all, and that reason is *limited*, not refuted - it cannot deliver the truth one must exist. The critique is powerful *because* it is internal to the Hegelian achievement: it strikes exactly where Hegel had located the Unhappy Consciousness and claimed a cure.

Verdict. The opposition is genuine but asymmetrical: Kierkegaard defeats Hegel on the ground of the individual and does not compete on the ground of system, which he does not want. The individual is the essence of spirit because spirit is a task to be *existed*, never a result to be *systematised*.

Why this earns marks: it renders the opposition structurally (either/or, leap, indirect communication) rather than as dislike of abstraction, cites the pseudonymous texts precisely, states the self-relation definition of spirit, and closes with the internal-critique verdict.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2023 Q3(c), 15 marks

Question: "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is." In the light of this statement bring out the chief features of Sartre's conception of consciousness.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

Model solution

Thesis. "Consciousness is what it is not and is not what it is" states the **non-self-identity of the pour-soi**: *unlike the en-soi (which simply is* what it is)*, human consciousness never coincides with itself, and this single formula grounds Sartre's accounts of freedom, bad faith and temporality.

Doctrine and evidence. The *en-soi* (being-in-itself) is full, solid, self-identical - "it is what it is." The *pour-soi* (being-for-itself) is consciousness, defined by **nihilation** (*neantisation*): it secretes nothingness, standing back from the given to question, negate and project. The two clauses unpack this: (a) consciousness "**is what it is not**" - it is always *ahead* of itself, defined by possibilities and a future that do not yet exist, so it *is* what it is not-yet; (b) consciousness "**is not what it is**" - it cannot coincide with its facticity/past: the waiter "is" a waiter and simultaneously "is not," because he transcends the role. (Sartre develops this in *Being and Nothingness*, 1943; the popular slogans belong to the 1945 lecture - keep the sources distinct.)

Analysis - what the formula does. Because consciousness is non-self-identical, it is **free** (no fixed nature binds it), capable of **bad faith** (it can hold a truth and its denial in one pre-reflective stance, needing no Freudian unconscious), and **temporal** (ecstatically stretched across past-present-future). The perpetual desire of the *pour-soi* is to become *en-soi* while keeping its consciousness - a self-identical yet self-aware being, the *pour-soi-en-soi* or **God** - which is contradictory, so "man is a **useless passion**."

Objection and reply. Is "non-self-identity" a genuine insight or a contradiction dressed in phenomenological language (analytic critics)? Sartre's reply is that the formula is descriptive of lived consciousness - the felt gap between what I am and what I take myself to be - not a formal claim about identity; the *datum* is the pre-reflective self-presence that is never coincidence.

Verdict. The formula is the key to Sartre's entire system: it makes freedom, bad faith, temporality and the "useless passion" intelligible from a single ontological root - which is exactly why an answer must reach that root, not merely gloss the sentence.

Why this earns marks: it separates and explains both clauses, grounds them in the *en-soi/pour-soi* contrast and nihilation, draws the systematic consequences (freedom, bad faith, useless passion), registers the coherence objection with a reply, and disciplines source attribution.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q1(e), 10 marks

Question: How does Kierkegaard define truth in terms of subjectivity? Critically discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

Model solution

Thesis. Kierkegaard defines existential truth in terms of subjectivity by locating it in the **how** of appropriation rather than the **what** of content: "an objective uncertainty held fast in the most passionate inwardness is the truth" - the highest truth available to an *existing* individual.

Doctrine and evidence. The claim is from the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript* (1846), by **Johannes Climacus** (cite the pseudonym). For objective disciplines - logic, mathematics, history - objective truth (correspondence, demonstration) is appropriate. But for the truths one must *exist* - ethical and, supremely, religious truth - what matters is the mode in which the individual holds them: with infinite passion, commitment and risk. Faith is the paradigm: to relate with infinite concern to "an objective uncertainty" is a higher truth than to possess a proof, because a proof would abolish the risk that constitutes faith.

Analysis - guarding the definition. Three clarifications keep the definition exact. (1) It is **not relativism**: "truth is subjectivity" concerns the *mode of appropriation*, not the propositional content; Kierkegaard does not deny objective truth, he denies its *sufficiency* for existence. (2) Its correlate is *den Enkelte*, the single individual; "the crowd is untruth," because truth so understood cannot be held by a public, only appropriated by one who stands alone. (3) It is completed by the complementary "**subjectivity is untruth**": before God the individual in sin is *in* untruth and needs the paradox of faith - so subjectivity is not self-congratulation but a task under judgment.

Objection and reply. The Hegelian/analytic charge is fideism and irrationalism - the leap abandons rational accountability. Kierkegaard's reply: reason is not *wrong* but *limited*; it cannot deliver what the existing individual needs, and the point of "truth is subjectivity" is to mark that limit, not to license arbitrariness.

Verdict. Kierkegaard's definition is a permanent corrective to the reduction of all truth to objective demonstration: for the truths that must be lived, *how* one holds them is itself part of their truth - defensible exactly because it is a thesis about appropriation, not a denial that anything is objectively so.

Why this earns marks: it states the definition in Kierkegaard's own terms, fixes the *how/what* distinction, pre-empts relativism with the complementary "subjectivity is untruth," attributes the text to Climacus, and rules on the fideism objection.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2024 Q4(a), 20 marks

Question: What do the existentialist thinkers mean by the slogan "existence precedes essence"? How is human existence related to human freedom according to them? Discuss.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md.

Model solution

Thesis. "Existence precedes essence" is **Sartre's** slogan for the reversal of the Western tradition: for human beings there is no pre-given nature or design; man first exists and then defines himself - and because there is no fixed essence, human existence is **radical freedom**. But "the existentialist thinkers" do not share the slogan uniformly, and this must be said.

The slogan and its argument. Sartre's argument (in the 1945 lecture *Existentialism Is a Humanism*, published 1946) runs from atheism: for an artefact - a **paper-knife** - the artisan's concept (essence, design, function) precedes the object's existence. Classical theism made God such an artisan of man, so human nature preceded human beings. Remove God, and the order reverses: **existence precedes essence** - man exists, encounters himself, and only afterward defines himself by his projects. There is no human nature because there is no God to conceive it.

"The existentialist thinkers" - the family, not a school. The demand's plural must be handled with care.

Kierkegaard, a Christian, never used the phrase; his cognate point is that the existing individual cannot be captured by Hegel's essence-System. **Heidegger** can say "the essence of Dasein lies in its existence," yet in the *Letter on Humanism* (1946/47) he **explicitly repudiates** Sartre's formula as a *metaphysical inversion* that stays within the metaphysics it means to escape. So only Sartre owns the slogan in the strict sense; treat "existentialism" as a family resemblance.

Existence related to freedom. If no essence is given, man is "**condemned to be free**" - freedom is not a property but our very being; it is total, inescapable, and attended by **anguish**. **Responsibility** follows: in choosing myself "**I choose man**," positing an image of humanity (quasi-Kantian universalisation). For Heidegger freedom is Dasein's thrown **projection** upon possibilities (not voluntarism); for Kierkegaard freedom is real but **bounded** - the leap

presupposes that one *can* choose.

Objection, reply, verdict. Critics ask whether ungrounded freedom can generate *values* without collapsing into decisionism; Sartre replies that the engagement of choice generates its own criteria, but the promised ethics of *Being and Nothingness* was never written. Verdict: the doctrine's force is that it makes evasion impossible - every appeal to nature, role or circumstance is itself a choice; its cost is that it struggles to say *why* one project is better than another.

Why this earns marks: it gives Sartre's atheistic argument and the paper-knife, corrects the plural by distinguishing all three thinkers (with Heidegger's repudiation and correct dates), links no-essence to radical freedom and responsibility, and closes with the decisionism objection and a graded verdict.

Solved PYQ 14 - 2025 Q1(c), 10 marks

Question: Explain the difference between being-for-itself and being-in-itself as presented by Sartre.

Source metadata: UPSC CSE Philosophy Optional, Paper I; exact wording, year and marks verified against [upsc-ai-kit/knowledge/Philosophy/paper-1/_PYQ-Western-Philosophy-2018-2025.md](#).

Model solution

Thesis. The difference between **being-for-itself** (*pour-soi*) and **being-in-itself** (*en-soi*) is the founding ontological dualism of Sartre's *Being and Nothingness* (1943): the *en-soi* simply *is* what it is, while the *pour-soi* is nihilating consciousness that *is not* what it is and *is* what it is not.

Being-in-itself (en-soi). The *en-soi* is being that is **full, solid, self-identical, opaque** and **without consciousness** - "it is what it is." A stone simply *is*; it has no inside, no distance from itself, no possibility, no lack. It is non-relational and complete, neither active nor passive, neither affirmation nor negation - massive positivity.

Being-for-itself (pour-soi). The *pour-soi* is **consciousness**, and its mode of being is **nihilation** (*neantisation*): it introduces nothingness into being by standing back from the given - questioning, negating, imagining, projecting beyond it. Hence the formulas: it **"is what it is not"** (it is ahead of itself, defined by possibilities and a future that do not yet exist) and **"is not what it is"** (it cannot coincide with its facticity/past - the waiter transcends the role he "is"). The *pour-soi* is **constituted by freedom**; it is lack, distance-from-self, perpetual self-surpassing.

Analysis - the relation between them. The two are not "matter" and "mind" (a common trap) but two *ontological* regions. Consciousness is always consciousness *of* the *en-soi* (intentionality), yet it is not itself a thing. The *pour-soi* perpetually desires to become *en-soi* **while keeping its self-awareness** - to be a self-identical *and* self-conscious being, the *pour-soi-en-soi*, which is the traditional idea of **God**. Because that synthesis is contradictory, the desire is doomed: **"man is a useless passion."**

Verdict. The distinction is the key to Sartre's system: freedom, bad faith and temporality all follow from the *pour-soi*'s non-self-identity as against the plenitude of the *en-soi*; the impossible longing to fuse the two defines human reality.

Why this earns marks: at 10 marks it stays crisp - defines both terms with their formulas, corrects the mind/matter misreading, and closes on the impossible *pour-soi-en-soi* (God) ideal and "useless passion," showing the distinction's systematic payoff.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Three original questions authored for this package (not PYQs), one each at 10, 15 and 20 marks, with full model solutions.

Original Mains 1

Original 10-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Existentialism | Answer in about 150 words

Question: Distinguish fear from anxiety (Angst / Angest / angoisse) in the existentialist tradition, and explain why anxiety is philosophically privileged.

Model solution

Thesis. Fear and anxiety differ not in intensity but in *object*: fear has a definite worldly object, anxiety has none, and this objectlessness is exactly why anxiety discloses existence itself.

Exposition. Fear (*Furcht/Frygt/peur*) is always fear of some entity - a dog, an exam - and it drives me back into the world for shelter. **Anxiety** (Heidegger's *Angst*, Kierkegaard's *Angest*, Sartre's *angoisse*) has "a nothing" for its object; because it is about no *thing*, it cannot disclose a thing, but instead a *structure* - my freedom (Kierkegaard, Sartre) or Being-in-the-world as such (Heidegger). Hence it *individualises*: the world's significance drains away and I stand alone.

Why privileged. Anxiety is the one mood in which the totality of existence becomes an issue, so it alone can motivate an existential analytic - Kierkegaard's dizziness of freedom, Heidegger's collapse of significance, Sartre's cliff.

Why this earns marks: it fixes the structural (object vs no-object) difference, names each thinker's term with correct provenance, and states the disclosive payoff within the word budget.

Original Mains 2

Original 15-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Existentialism | Answer in about 250 words

Question: Examine Sartre's account of the Look (*le regard*) and being-for-others. Does 'conflict' exhaust our relations with others?

Model solution

Thesis. The Look is Sartre's proof that the Other is encountered as a *subject* who objectifies me, not inferred as a probable mind; but the conclusion that "conflict is the original meaning of being-for-others" rests on one contestable premise, and once it is dropped, non-conflictual relations become possible.

Exposition. *Being and Nothingness* (1943) adds a third ontological dimension, **being-for-others** (*l'être-pour-autrui*). The keyhole scene supplies the evidence: absorbed, spying, there is no ego in my awareness; then footsteps - I am **seen**, and instantly I become an object with a nature I did not choose. **Shame** "is by nature recognition" that "I am as the Other sees me"; the Other is "the indispensable mediator between myself and me." This is a genuine advance on Husserl's analogical appresentation, because the Other is lived as subject, not constituted as a sense.

Critical assessment. Recognition then fails both ways: to *possess* the Other's free look (love, masochism) destroys the freedom I wanted, and to *reduce* the Other to an object (sadism, hate) forfeits the recognition I sought - hence conflict. But this follows only from the premise that being-subject and being-object are *mutually exclusive*. Drop it, and trust, solidarity and love become relations to a free Other without objectification. Sartre's own later "group-in-fusion" (*Critique*, 1960) and Levinas's ethics of the face are two ways of dropping it.

Verdict. The Look is a decisive phenomenological insight into shame; the generalisation to universal conflict is its most vulnerable step.

Why this earns marks: it reconstructs the keyhole and shame, states the advance on Husserl, isolates the exclusivity premise, and adduces Sartre's own later self-correction and Levinas as evidence.

Original Mains 3

Original 20-mark | Philosophy Paper I, Western Philosophy - Existentialism | Answer in about 250 words

Question: Compare the conceptions of authenticity in Kierkegaard, Sartre and Heidegger. Is 'authenticity' a single doctrine across the three thinkers?

Model solution

Thesis. "Authenticity" is not one doctrine but a family of related demands: the three thinkers agree that the existing individual must *own* its existence rather than lose itself in the anonymous, yet they differ sharply on *before what* one becomes authentic and on whether authenticity has moral content.

Kierkegaard. Authenticity is emphatically *content-full*: it is achieved before **God**, in the religious sphere, by the **leap** (Kierkegaard's *Springet*; "leap of faith" is the English tradition's phrase) out of the aesthetic and ethical. Its enemy is "the crowd", its mood **anxiety** (*Angest*), its exemplar the knight of faith. Selfhood is a self-relation grounded in the power that posited it.

Sartre. Authenticity is *owning radical freedom* and refusing **bad faith** - neither hiding in facticity (the waiter) nor denying it. There is **no God** and no given values, so authenticity legislates for all in choosing ("in choosing myself I choose man"); yet the promised ethics was never written, so its content stays thin.

Heidegger. Authenticity (*Eigentlichkeit*) is an **ontological modification**, *not* a moral virtue: owning one's thrown projection through the call of conscience and **being-toward-death**. Its notorious cost is **formal emptiness** - it says *how*, not *which*.

Verdict. The shared form is *owning versus dispersal*; the differences (God vs freedom vs finitude; content-full vs formal) are deeper than the resemblance. Treat "authenticity" as a family term, never a single thesis - Heidegger even denied he was an existentialist (*Letter on Humanism*, 1947).

Why this earns marks: it states the shared form, contrasts the three on ground and content, weaves in correct provenance (Springer, *Letter on Humanism*), and rules that the term is a family resemblance, not one doctrine.